Life Is A Highway

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Life Is A Highway

by Salted_Toffee

Summary

"And the mission is?"

"A road trip, so to speak."

Hordak quirked his brow. "Ooooh-kay."

"There is an Intergalactic Conference in the Summit solar system, few galaxies away. Glimmer needs to attend in the next few days. It's quite possibly the most important event in Etheria's history."

"And what does the conference pertain to? If I may ask?"

"Securing Etheria's status in the universe. Glimmy wants to appeal to The Council of The Known Universe and have Etheria recognised as a developed-enough world to join The Council. Ever since Etheria had been freed from Despandos it has been at the mercy of the rest of the universe. As a magical mediaeval world, Etheria's has been seen by the rest of the universe as 'underdeveloped' and 'primitive' and as 'defenceless'. Becoming a part of The Council will grant us safety. Their technology advancements. Limitless food and medicine - access to planets they've constructed dedicated solely to agriculture and harvesting. Respect among other worlds. The Council of The Known Universe, turns out, was established to create a barricade against tyrant empires like Prime and The Galactic Horde. Etheria needs protection like that, but there's a problem."

Notes

LIFE IS A HIGHWAY!

Written by (me)

Art by the absolutely supreme @themazziah @cosmiccanineart on tumblr, please go show them some love!

Created as part of The Spop Big Bang 2024

I just want to say thank you to The Mazziah who also goes by Cosmiccanineart for creating this absolutely gorgeous piece of art that you're looking at right now. It was so good in fact that I was inspired to rewrite the story to incorporate it into the narrative. When writers and artists were being paired up, I was sure I'd be left without a partner, but after they said that I was their first choice I was honestly so moved and touched. Thank you for picking me. Nothing I write could ever express how lovely it feels to read a kind comment like that. And that's why I'll try to get back into writing Entrapdak fics, it's been a while, and I'd love to do more, the world can never have enough Entrapta and Hordak in it. (and Glimmadora, my first time writing them, hope I did okay) Thanks, Mazz, if you read this, I hope this story gives you a good few chuckles.

Finally, on a more personal note, this is a three parter, I could only manage to finish Act One before the deadlines as I was working on my final university assignments at the same time, and now I'm finished and free! And I can't think of a better way to celebrate! I'll try to get the rest of the story out as soon as possible. I hope you enjoy this little space road trip.

Chapter 1



Life Is A Highway

Act One (of Three)

~One Year After The Defeat of Horde Prime

CloneTown, or as the inhabitants of the settlement chose to dub it, Doormat, was a small shanty town at the foot of Mount Dryl on top of which Castle Dryl stood. The doormat of Dryl, of Etheria, of the universe, Adora assumed that was the intended joke. The warrior of light examined the sign closely, a hastily put together sign stood before her, it read: 'Welcome To' with CloneTown crossed out. A separate board, made of wood not matching the rest of the sign, was nailed underneath, on it carved crudely was 'Doormat'. Adora never knew clones had a sense of humour, then again, it wasn't like she spent much time among them. Or at all. As She-Ra, the Protector of Etheria, she visited many villages on the continent, observed as many cultures of as many people as she could, opened her heart and reached out a helping hand to all... all except the newest refugees of Etheria. Every time she had ventured to a clone settlement, she felt unease - most villages across Etheria worshipped her (so to speak, and that invited its own unique forms of exhaustion), but when she set foot on clone grounds, she felt unwanted, which of course, she was. Perhaps the unease emerged from the fact that all the staring eyes that silently watched her stroll into town as she did so now, all belonged to the same face, the face of her old master. One she worshipped in her youth, but no longer. But that didn't matter now, now she was walking down the muddy roads of Doormat, and attracting quite a few puzzled, angered glares. Adora approached in her normal form, strolling up as a 9-foot-tall glowing, radiant, goddess might have been a bit too much. Not that it mattered too much as she still stuck out like a sore thumb, she was the only non-clone in the village, nothing she could do about that. The warrior was cloaked in torn and tattered robes, a hood obscuring her face, so at least they didn't know who she was.

Soon enough the Warrior of Grayskull happened upon her destination, Bar Nefcy, a local, clone-ran establishment. She got a bit lost, but Entrapta's directions were correct. There was a hanging sign spelling out the bar's name in uncharacteristically bright pink paint. Almost acting as a centrepiece of the town. From what she heard about it, the establishment acted as a sort of neutral ground for clones: regs, defects, and whatever came between. And as she entered the establishment, she wondered whether that mentality and ideology would extend to her. And almost immediately she got her answer as the chatter throughout the room stopped, all the various patrons turned to look at her, a sea of red and green eyes staring into her. She wasn't exactly scared, if anything came down to violence, she had plenty to keep herself safe, including the enormous broadsword channelling cosmic energy that would transform her into the most powerful woman in the universe. Adora made her way over to the barline and sat herself down, each of her footsteps making the wooden floor creak, which could be heard over the silence.

She attempted to stay invisible and stay silent until her contact would show up, however that turned out to be unlikely as she caught a glimpse of her bartender, a small "Oh!" escaped her and she immediately regretted it, and felt awful about it. Adora's bartender did not look like a regular clone, he was downright bizarre, he was overgrown with vines, flowers, and moss, all intertwined and weaved into the clone's being. Where his eyes would be, now two thick vines ran outward spreading into a patch of moss and grass atop his head. Effectively rendering the man, blind. Admittedly, she stared for a bit too long, but she didn't think he'd know.

"Well?!"

"?"

"I may be as blind as a bat, but my hearing is as good as ever. I heard you walk in and sit down, the floorboards are on purpose. So? What'ya want?"

Adora gulped, and put on her best diplomatic voice, “No drink for me, sir. I only ask permission to stay in your bar for- I don't know, uh, a few more minutes. I'm meeting a... friend, shall we call him. A clone. I'm a friend! An ally!” Whoof. She never had to pull that card out before. The bartender didn't seem to look convinced. The diplomatic voice slipped halfway through all that. “Please.” She finished with an awkward smile on her pinched face.

“Uh huh, look this is a clone-establishment, not for… natives. You're unsettling my clientele, so if you'd be so kind and find the exit as I can't, ya know on the account of a magic flower growing out of my face. Good day, Princess.” Wait he knew? How? Was her voice that recognisable?

Just then another voice rose from the back of the bar, from a far corner booth, “Ah, come on Manny! I thought this was a ‘neutral ground’ and whatnot. You gonna denie the guy their poison? They're just trying to get through today like the rest of us.” The bartender, who Adora now knew was named Manny, groaned in annoyance, if he could roll his eyes, he would have. Adora turned around to see where the voice was coming from. There, far in the back, in the corner booth, set an elderly patron a clone no doubt, he spoke with the same voice. But he too looked downright bizarre, unlike all the other clones. This clone was thin, like a skeleton, he looked sickly. (A defect, they were called, she believed, though not entirely sure). The lower half of his face looked normal enough, well for a clone that was. But the top half of his head was a glass-like red dome with some strange displays flashing inside like a radar monitor. And not only that, protruding out of his face was a long witch-like nose, sharp as a knife. Almost as sharp as the red teeth that formed a, what was meant to be a friendly, smile.

The clone wore a mechanical suit (of armour?) that framed his skeletal features. His feet were kicked up on top of the table. His feet resembled… clamps? Like mechanical vulture talons. There was another clone at the corner booth with them, but they had their back turned to Adora, they were clearly uninterested in this interaction. The vulture-like clone stood up and wobblingly

made his way over to Adora. It was clear he was drunk. But from Manny’s reaction she gauged that this was his default state. The bird-like man spoke up again, “Leave the freak alone. ‘Serve all, not one’, right?” The woman noticed that the clone acted as if he had a cup or glass in his hand... But he didn't, there was no drink in his curved hand.

“V,” Manny spoke, so that was his name, “Should have known this freak was with you, something always happens when you're around here. Trouble seems to follow you wherever you go, and you always bring it here. So why don't you take your royal friend, and go lead trouble away from here.”

“I won't cause any trouble, I promise.” Adora proclaimed, she reached into her coat pocket and pulled out a piece of paper, she placed the page onto the table and slid it over to Manny. “I'm actually here on behalf of the Queen, to hand you this Establishment License to let you run your business officially... it was illegal before, just so you know. As a show of gratitude and togetherness.” Adora gave her best smile. Manny just looked at the piece of paper and groaned, he turned around and walked off with the paper in hand, grumpy. Adora swivelled around back to V, she awkwardly thanked them, “Hey, thanks, uh, V was it? For taking my side. And I'm sorry I caused a commotion here.”

“Eh,” He waved dismissively, “Don't take it too personally kid, Manny over there's still a little peeved that you turned him and a bunch of others into walking compost heaps back when you turned The Velvet Glove into a giant tree, heh.”

“I- I did that to him?”

“Oh, not just him, every clone hibernating in a pod and whatnot. Thousands.”

“Oh, gods, what have I done.” She murmured to herself, she combed through her hair, a thousand yard stare on her face. “I'm so sorry... I didn't know I was unwelcome.”

“Eh,” He shrugged, “Don't take that too personally either, neither is he.” V pointed behind him with his thumb towards the doorway. Adora followed the thumb to the silhouette in the door frame. Hordak. Her drinking partner had arrived.

The Ex-Lord of the Horde entered the establishment and silence befell the bar once more, the collective of eyes glared at him and followed him as he slowly made his way over to the warrior Princess. Not too different of a reaction that they greeted Adora with. V just then realised there wasn't a drink in his hand and so he moved out of the way to give Hordak room to sit down next to Adora. He did so. The villain maintained silence, Adora thought it was to seem intimidating, but in reality he simply had no idea how to talk to people, and was too awkward to be the one to begin the conversation.

Hordak was cloaked in a black cape and hood. His blue, curly, fringe poking out from under the hood. Another thing she just now noticed about Hordak was that his eyes were different, usually fully blood red with black makeup around, just now realising that those must have been contact lenses of some sort, because now she witnessed his real eyes. Soft and organic rather than the glass shields which is what their texture usually looked like. Now his corneas were fully pitch black with black pupils and bright blood red irises, the way they shifted about it somehow made him far more emotive. He was clad in matte black and gun metal grey plated armour with neon red highlights running throughout. No Horde symbol on his chest plate however, The Wings of The Vampire where nowhere to be seen. What Adora didn't see was the First One's crystal embedded within his armour powering his entire suit. He wore the same double slit dress he always wore, thighs on full display. That was certainly a choice.

Adora spoke up first, “Sooo, ahem, I'm sure you're wondering why I asked to meet with you.”

“Yes.” He spoke with his deep, smooth voice, “Entrapta, my dearest, did not disclose why you wished to meet. And why here

of all places. I am usually summoned to BrightMoon by the Queen."

"Weeeell, I thought meeting here might make you feel more comfortable. Heard this place serves drinks to anyone, guess... guess not."

"Hmm, indeed. I do not drink here. I am unwelcome. I do not blame anyone for that belief. My shunning is just."

"I thought you'd be a hero to your people, especially after killing Prime and all."

" *You* killed Prime. I'm surprised many of my brothers haven't turned to worship you She-Ra Adora."

"It's just Adora. And more people 'worshipping' me is the last thing I want."

"And as to why many of my brothers hate me? Well, everyone has their own reasons. For many I will always be that authority figure, a High-General, sending them off to their deaths. For others, like Manny here, good man that Manny, they believe my... 'campaign' here has led to your people hating them. I destroyed any chance of a peaceful coexistence. I am keen to agree with him."

Adora didn't disagree, but there was more to it. She did not want to unpack all of it just yet so she chose to instead change the topic of conversation, "Hordak. The reason I wanted to meet with you... I have a job for you."

"I imagined as much. However, it is usually the Queen who imparts assignments upon me and my brothers. Why this-breaking of routine?"

"Because this concerns the Queen. This 'job' isn't her idea, it's mine, in fact, it took a lot of convincing to get her onboard."

"And the mission is?"

“A road trip, so to speak.”

Hordak quirked his brow. “Ooooh-kay.”

“There is an Intergalactic Conference in the Summit solar system, few galaxies away. Glimmer needs to attend in the next few days. It's quite possibly the most important event in Etheria’s history.”

“And what does the conference pertain to? If I may ask?”

“Securing Etheria’s status in the universe. Glimmy wants to appeal to The Council of The Known Universe and have Etheria recognised as a developed-enough world to join The Council. Ever since Etheria had been freed from Despandos it has been at the mercy of the rest of the universe. As a magical mediaeval world, Etheria’s has been seen by the rest of the universe as ‘underdeveloped’ and ‘primitive’ and as ‘defenceless’. Becoming a part of The Council will grant us safety. Their technology advancements. Limitless food and medicine - access to planets they’ve constructed dedicated solely to agriculture and harvesting. Respect among other worlds. Protection from other tyrants across the cosmos like Prime. Make sure it never happens again. The Council of The Known Universe, turns out, was established to create a barricade against tyrant empires like Prime and The Galactic Horde. Etheria needs protection like that, but there's a problem.”

Hordak placed a hand against his chin as he pondered on the matter, “The Primusians.”

“Yes. You've heard?”

“I have, through the ‘grapevine’ as you would call it; clones talk, or think (telepathically), especially here. V doesn't keep anything to himself. Primus pirates have been assaulting crafts around the system, many of them clones seeking home off-world. They've been quite active since our ‘stunt’ with the Minister of

Armament and Defence. You're afraid they have their sights set on the Queen. Making transporting her a major risk.”

“Yeah, you got it. I knew you'd catch on.” Hordak shot her an inquisitive look as well as a bombastic side eye, “Anyway, the plan is to send a new unmanned decoy ship on the route to the conference. Pirates explode it, and hopefully they'll think the bodies got incinerated.”

“That's that then.” Hordak remarked satisfied.

“Yeah, except Glim still needs to make it to Summit. And that's where you, and your... team comes in. I hear you have a ship, don't know how, but you do. You'll escort Glim on the longer way around the Black Donut system and deliver her to the conference on time.”

“That will take days.”

“One week exactly. One way each. That's why I’m here now, the Queen’s orders.”

“It does not sound like the Queen would be thrilled about this idea. My brothers can be... a lot.”

“She isn't. But she knows it's the right thing to do.”

Hordak sighed. “Adora why would I-“

“Because you owe me.” She suddenly became incredibly serious, her glare at Hordak hardened, and Hordak fell silent. He really did. Freeing him from Prime’s influence. Dropping in a good word for him at his trial. He most likely wouldn't have been with Entrapta at all without her. He simply nodded in agreement. “And... because I love her.”

“And you would trust me to keep her safe?”

“The same way I'll keep Entrapta safe while you're gone... So? Deal?”

- - -

Day One (of Seven)

“No. No deal.” Glimmer remarked defeated. “This is a bad- ugh- I don't like this plan, just stating that for the record.” The Queen of BrightMoon spoke to the holo-pad, arguing with the screen. On the other side of the screen was a smiling but slightly scared Adora. Glimmer marched through the corridors of Castle Dryl, the never-ending labyrinth, that Glimmer was 80% sure was constantly shifting, trying to confuse her. It didn't help that she was constantly going down, deeper into the mountain. Entrapta was the master of traps after all. But Glimmer continued on her path anyhow. She had a map display hovering over the holo-pad that clearly outlined where to go. And surely this wasn't a trap, a planned scheme to assassinate her, right?

“I know what you're thinking; It's not a trap.”

“I- wasn't thinking... that.” She squinted at the map overhead, “I swear the corridors are moving, how is that even possible. It also doesn’t fill me with confidence that Entrapta called this, ‘The Basement’.” The monarch wore her traditional purple outfit, glittering cape, golden accents around the belt, shoulder pauldron, and of course her royal tiara. Her stern look faded away and a sadness took its place. “Why couldn't you’ve come with me?”

“~Oh, StarLight, I'm sorry. I want to always be at your side, and I would be if I could. But the strange signals emanating from the Crystal Castle, it could mean LightHope’s back. And if LightHope *is* back, which *her* is she? And why would she be transmitting off-world?”

“So you'll be on the other side of the universe.”

“As soon as I'm done I'll B-line it to you. Just- just wait for me. You're in good hands until then.”

"...I wish I could hold you, I miss you already." Glimmer's words brought a warm smile to the She-Ra's face. Adora turned away, avoiding eye contact, a blush rising across her face.

"I miss you too. But please, trust me, it'll be okay." Adora turned to look at something out of the holo-pad's view, she sighed, "I have to go. I love you. See you in a week."

And the transmission terminated.

Glimmer sighed. Already missing Adora's voice. She believed she was approaching her destination, a large mechanical door stood before her. The GPS on her holo-pad indicated that she had reached 'The Hangar'. "Okay." She accepted the journey ahead with one word. Glimmer swiped the touchscreen on her whole pad, the bypass code got transmitted to the control panel at the doors ahead. The green light indicated the door unlocking. And the metal doors slid upward with a hiss. A light spilled into the corridor, so much so Glimmer had to shield her eyes with her hand. She took a step inside and almost tripped over immediately. She looked back to see what it was, and noticed that the floor was littered with a variety of… strange and seemingly unrelated things; Pipes, cables, and various other pieces of machinery, she guessed. There were also art supplies; Paint buckets, brushes, canvases, and spray cans. As she turned around to face forward once again she ducked immediately as she was almost closelined by a low hanging clothing line, various photographs hung up along it. Various landscapes from the brief glimpse that Glimmer caught of it.

"Look out." A familiar voice called out, but it came from an unfamiliar character. Glimmer followed the voice to match it to the clone face. The man wasn't even looking at her, which meant she must have yelped quite loudly at some point. She re-composed herself and made her way to the clone, the closer she got, the more details revealed themselves to her. The man was, in fact, a clone, he had the same voice and Hordak's face, but that was almost where the similarities ended. The tuft of hair on top of his head was dyed in a patchwork of every colour, it was quite

strange seeing all that colour on a clone. But the most defining characteristic was the fact that he was wheelchair bound due to his two missing legs, amputated just above the knees. The defect was sat in front of a sizable canvas, a paintbrush in hand and in the middle of creating a new painting. The painting was, no doubt about it, gorgeous. It depicted Doormat, at the foot of Mount Dryl. The light that had blinded Glimmer earlier when she entered had come from the massive open hangar bay doors letting the daylight in. She assumed that was where he got the photos and references from.

"It's beautiful." She remarked.

"What? This? Thank you, but no, it's just a warm up, and it's hideous. I think I might be having an off day. See that tree?" The clone pointed to a perfectly fine tree on the painting.

"Right." She should have probably introduced herself, "I'm-"

"Cargo." He finished.

"Not how I'd like to put it. But yeah, I- uh- I'm Glimmer."

"I know. You're the Queen. You send me and my brothers on suicide missions."

"Yeah... uhmm, yes, soooorry about that, and you are?"

"Moe."

"Moe. I'll- I'll remember that. Is Hordak here?"

"He's with Entrapta, doing… whatever mad-scientists do. Making time travelling microwaves that send your meal forward in time to when it's already done?"

"Heh, it's Entrapta, it wouldn't surprise me. She can do anything she sets her mind to."

The joke seemed to resonate with the artist, he smiled, “We're taking off soon, Dak’ll be down in a bit, feel free to get set up on the ship, try getting used to it, the trip’ll be a few days long.”

“Thanks.”

Glimmer turned to the ship in question, The Annihilation it was called. It was a Horde troop carrier dropship repurposed as a mobile home to The Defects as they recently began calling themselves. Looks like they were really owning it. The dropship had a new paint job, no doubt thanks to Moe, an angry face painted over the cockpit, angry eyes and a row of sharp teeth. And a mural on the side of the hull, abstract, but unfinished, she presumed. The ship had Christmas lights hung up all along it, a TV satellite dish on top, and a footpath leading to the lowered ramp into the loading bay. The Annihilation was surrounded by a white picket fence, turf of fake grass, a small cheap fountain (kinda ugly, with a gnome spitting out water at the centre). And a mailbox at the front, not that anyone ever sent in any mail, it was all very cute however.

The Queen of Light made her way into the loading bay, up the ramp, and quickly realised it was... A living room? A TV, a couch, and a carpet. All bolted down so it wouldn't fly out presumably. She was surprised at the mundanity of it all, she was expecting something far more alien or militaristic. While her head was in the clouds she tripped yet again. She growled at her own clumsiness, “What? Do I have two left feet today? What now?” She looked down at what had tripped her up and she almost jumped out of her skin. It was a man, slumped over, on the ground, leaning against a wall, a cable lodged into the back of his head. He was silent, he wasn't moving. Glimmer’s thoughts raced madly; He's dead. They killed someone and stuffed him into their ship. She was looking at a corpse right now!

Then a voice came from above, “Heh, you know that happened to me once.” She looked up to see a skinny man hanging upside down from the ceiling like a bat, he smiled with

his bright red fangs, “Mortar shell. Blew me into pieces. Turns out I grabbed someone else’s leg! HA!”

“...Wh- What?”

“Two left feet! We all match so the joints just pop in! Customizable action figures, batteries sold separately.” V cackled to himself as he descended from the ceiling and landed before the monarch. Glimmer wasn't sure how to respond, or what she was looking at, some sort of birdman? She was at a loss for words, since her mind was still on the potential corpse at her feet. “V.” He indicated himself with his hand.

“Is this a dead body?!” She pointed to the clone on the floor in panic and anguish. V craned his neck to look past the Queen. V waved it off matter of factly.

“Eh, don't worry about Drag. Kid’s just taking a nap.”

“So I shouldn't be worried?”

“Oh, well, no, you definitely should. ‘Nap’ so to speak. The truth is far more horrifying. You see little Drag is in a state of constant rapid brain degradation the curjigger he's hooked up to continuously recreates his brain through... woff nanobots? I don't know, Dak’s the one who does machines. The boy fainted not long ago, so he'll be out for a good while.”

“How long is he usually out for?” She still asked panicked.

“Uh, I don't know, varies, sometimes hours, sometimes days, whatever the story needs really. I'm sure he'll be back by the third act.”

“... What are you talking about?”

“I don't know. Anyways, make yourself at home, but not too much, the chaotic mess is on purpose.”

"The 'I know where everything is' type of organisation system?"

"What? No, I don't know where anything is, it's just to annoy Hordak. Sometimes I dump buckets of mud and dust inside just to see how furrowed his brows can get. Ha! He gets so angry."

Glimmer just now noticed that V had patted the couch as he made his 'make yourself at home' statement. "Wait, I'm… sleeping on the couch?" She remarked in disbelief.

"Weeell, yeah, what did you expect?"

"A room?!"

"Ahhh... No. Heh. No."

"Unbelievable."

"Hey, it's not *that* bad, this is the best spot on Anni! You got a perfect view of the TV (which has channels from the next three galaxies). A few itchy blankets and who knows what wonders hide between the couch cushions; Just today I found Drag's goldfish's food... Oh shoot, I knew I forgot something." He tapped his chin.

"I'm in Hel. I died, and now I'm in Hel."

"HA! Not yet. But The End is coming. Soon!" V waltzed away saluting her away as he ventured off to check up on his younger brother's fish.

"Wait! Can't I have Drag's room? Or is his room the corridor?" She asked sarcastically.

"Sorry, Candy Floss, he ain't interchangeable. You'll just have to deal with it." The doors to Drag's bedroom closed and he was out of earshot.

"...Great. Perfect. Great idea, Adora. Thanks, hun."

- - -

“I wish you could stay.” Entrapta sadly remarked.

Hordak took a moment to reply, he looked away and down, “... As do I, Beloved.”

It was another day, another mission and once again the universe had decided to tear them apart as it often did. It was especially bittersweet and tragic as the couple had plans for today, family picnic, so to speak. Entrapta sighed as she soldered the motherboard in front of her, their mask down and covering her face, “I was really looking forward to working on the power couplings for the hyper light telescope. I bet we can see the Lynks system from here! I heard rumours that they've managed to construct an entire artificial star! It powers their two nearest colonies!... I- I can wait for you... And we could do it together when you get back, how long can the escort be? Two?- Three days?” She tried to keep up a genuine smile.

“We estimate a week to the Summit system, and one week to return.” Hordak hid most of himself under his cape like a weighted blanket, “I know how much you love star gazing, you shouldn't have to wait for me. You should enjoy yourself without me.” He reached out for Entrapta’s hand. Entrapta let go of the soldering iron, and accepted the taloned hand of her partner. The Ex-Lord of the Horde softly massaged her hand, his thumb moving in circles.

She gently squeezed Hordak’s hand in return, “But I'd love for you to be with me. Us, together, you know?” She snuggled into Hordak’s chest, leaning her head against him. Dak held her hand and placing his other hand against Entrapta’s back, a gentle touch, “That's the life I wanted for us.” She murmured lowly, almost a purr.

“I know.” Hordak spoke solemnly.

"...It feels like we're apart every day now. I thought things would get better… and here you go again."

"I know. But this request- it came from-"

"Adora, I know." Entrapta lifted her mask, revealing a small smile, "That's the only thing I like about this." That made Hordak raise one of his brows, "You, opening up to her, it's cute. She's a good girl. I'm glad you're making new friends." She patted Hordak's chest.

"Well, I wouldn't go *that* far-"

" *Hordak.* "

"Ah!" Hordak jumped, scared by the voice inside his head. The clone turned around to find Lee, another one of his brothers, just standing there – Menacingly. "Lee! How did you- ? Where? Why?!"

" *We have a problem.* "

Italics indicate telepathy – Toffee

"What?"

" *The Queen is currently in our home.* "

"Yes, she is the cargo."

" *…Why was I not informed of this?* "

"Because you wouldn't have liked it."

" *We are transporting (possibly) the most powerful woman in the universe - that is going to turn heads, and paint a target on our backs. Are we not meant to be secret task force?* "

"That is why we and the She-Ra are the only individuals aware of this mission. And, were you not the one who urged me to establish a more trusting relationship with the rulers of this

world? Do you not think that a favour such as this would aid in improving relations between clones and natives?" Lee pondered on it, he nodded. He would have grunted if he could, unfortunately for Lee, his entire lower jaw was missing. By far his most noticeable and unique feature.

"...Sooo? Are we-? Is this-? Are we done? I'm just getting half of the conversation here, just so you know." Entrapta poked in.

Suddenly V also appeared out of nowhere behind Hordak, "Hey we have a problem."

"Gahhh! Where did you?! How- What?! Ugh. Yes, we know; the Queen." Hordak face palmed.

"What? No. It's Drag's goldfish, it's dead."

"What? I thought you were feeding it."

"I thought Lee was feeding it."

" *Well, I thought Moe was feeding it.* "

Hordak sighed, face in his hands, "Fine, we'll figure it out on the road, just go, get out of here."

Lee just looked at him, and turned away, " *I'll be on the ship. I'm assuming all the relevant mission information is on board?* " Hordak nodded. " *Then I will be there, studying.* " And the clone disappeared as soon as he appeared. V followed.

"He's scary good at that." Entrapta remarked.

"Hmm."

"I don't think he likes me."

"They'll come around..."

Both of them stood there for a moment, in silence. “So... you should probably get going.” Entrapta remarked sadly, not ready to let go again so quickly.

“Mmm.” Hordak looked around the lab, “Where is Imp? I wished to say goodbye to him before departing.”

“Probably hiding, lil rascal hates to see you go. He misses you you know.”

“I know…” A sadness washed over his face.

“Look, I know you're at work, the last thing you need up there is me. But-”

“I would spend my entire life at your side! I love your voice. I adore your beautiful mind. And worship your heart for all the love you have offered me. You are not a hindrance!”

“Okay, okay, haha.” She looked down at the ground with a warm blush on her cheeks, “I know, I get it.”

“You think so little of yourself, I know how you are. And I do not appreciate it.” He landed a soft kiss on his partner's cheek. Which drew a chuckle from her.

“OK, OK, enough! You know I can't take compliments!” She exclaimed joyously as she smooshed his cheeks with her soft gloved hands.

“It is my duty as your lab partner to remind you of your worth, your beauty and your wonder, and that is just a scientific fact. Now, what- uh- what were you going to say before I rudely interrupted?”

From a large pouch on her utility belt Entrapta fished out a small Rubik’s cube-like object, which shifted in her palm and unfolded into a large two-handed holo-pad, and handed it over to Dak, “You know how I've been working on the intergalactic communications array?! So, I've been working on downsizing it

and managed to incorporate it into a screened device - this holo-pad will allow us to stay in touch, even worlds apart. It's only a prototype, of course, but it should work perfectly."

What a loving gift. Entrapta always bestowed such wonderful presents, Perfuma proclaimed that it was her love-language. Hordak did not understand what that meant exactly, but his mind wondered, how could he further 'communicate' in this 'language'? "Beloved, I- This is a most thoughtful gift, but... it is standard protocol to not take any contraband that could possibly link us to and could be traced back to Etheria in case the ship is breached... but, I suppose with the literal Queen of Etheria on board, that rule does not apply." He smiled. Entrapta matched the smile.

"I will call you, when you're on your way, later today." She raised on her tippy-toes and kissed her tall partner on the cheek, "Keep you company."

"I would appreciate it."

Hordak and Entrapta lost themselves in each other's eyes as they often did, they wordlessly embraced in a warm hug. Their foreheads found each other, eyes closed, they allowed themselves to smile just a little.

"I love you."

"I love you, more."

"Scientifically impossible, I love you far more."

"No, I love you more!" They giggled softly to each other.

- - -

Glimmer had unpacked, to the best of her abilities, that is to say she was pecking at one of her packed lunch sandwiches and marked the couch as her territory by placing her luggage all over it. The Queen was now just sitting on the couch, slouched.

This was going to be a long trip, she could tell. So she tried to distract herself by glueing herself to the TV. Unfortunately, the channel she was watching was broadcasting from an alien system with a language she did not understand. She could infer from the tone of the voice and the acting what was going on. It was some sort of telenovela, ooorr a reality TV show? No, Glimmer had no idea where the remote was. So that was it, her life for the next week. Hopefully Adora and the rest of the Princesses would take her on the way back after the conference.

"Oh, nice, that's a good episode."

"What?" She turned back to see V standing behind her like a dad at a BBQ over a grill, a coffee mug in hand.

"Sapphire Lakes. Great show. A handful of wealthy women who pretend to be friends are locked up in a small lake house for a week where they scream, lie and backstab each other for a cash prize. It's truly peak television. Tiffany's just confronting Jade about cheating with Keith." He pointed gleefully at the screen.

"How do you know all this? It's not even in Etherian?"

V taped the side of his head, presumably where his ears would be, wait, did he even have ears? "Air-Vibration Translators. Convert any nearby language to clone speak."

"Huh."

"Your majesty." Glimmer's eyes followed the voice to the clone entering the drop ship, it was Hordak. Long black cape covering his body and draping behind him on the floor. His battle armour underneath, no longer bearing the symbol of the Horde, but rather the symbol of Dryl, purple gear with a star at its centre. Proud property of his wife.

"Hordak, finally. I wanted to speak with you." Glimmer spoke up.

"Lee here?" Dak turned to V.

“Yeah, he’s in.” V replied, still glued to the TV screen.

“What? I didn't see anyone enter.” Glim remarked confused.

“Yeah, that's Lee. If he wants to, you won't see him all week.” V shrugged.

“One can only hope.” She murmured.

“I see you've already gotten acquainted with the crew. Uh- Make yourself at home, I suppose. We depart soon.”

“Uh- Thanks...”

“...”

“...”

“...Soooo, How- uh- how are you?...”

“Yeah, I'm- I'm good- I'm alright... How... Are you?”

“Good. Good...

“... Yeah.”

“... Alright, let's go.” He awkwardly turned around and departed to the ship's cockpit.

V stopped on the way, “Hey, Daky, beloved brother of mine, my favourite person in the whole wide cosmos.”

“What do you want?” Hordak sounded tired already.

“Can I drive?”

“No.”

“I'm a pilot! I was a pilot back in the day! I'm good at flying. I'm a pilot... Can I-?”

“You are not touching my ship.”

“But you let Entrapta work on the ship!?”

“That, dear brother, is because she's competent.”

Glimmer huffed as she leaned against the couch cushions, “This is going to be a long week.” She returned to her slouching.

Hordak marched up the small steps that led to the cockpit which was a narrow space; and sat one on the front seat, the pilot seat from which one would steer the ship via the steering wheel and the numerous unlabelled buttons covering the control panels on either side of the wheel, some blinking, some not. (How Hordak knew to press what, was beyond this trans-fourth-dimensional narrator.) V attempted to flick a switch, but his hand was slapped away by Dak, who didn't even take his eyes off the panel. V frowned like a toddler that was denied cookies from their mom, and he fell down onto the back seat of the cockpit, the navigator seat. The navigator would advise routes throughout space and monitor the status of the ship.

A finger taped Glimmer on the shoulder, she turned to see Moe, now on board, “Can I take some of these?” He asked, pointing to the pillows on the couch.

“Uh, yeah, sure.” She handed the clone the pillows, and watched him make his way to Drag. Moe climbed down from his wheelchair and gently moved his brother to lean forward, still unconscious, and placed a pillow behind his head. He wanted to lift his younger brother and place another pillow under him, but Moe, being a defect, was unable to lift his weight. So, he was surprised when Drag *did* lift up. He looked up surprised to see that Glimmer had lifted the comatose clone up by the underarms. Moe was pleasantly shocked for a moment, but continued and placed a pillow for Drag to sit on and one to lean against. Glimmer lowered him, and helped Moe up onto his wheelchair. And pushed his wheelchair to the couch.

“Thanks- Bay doors.” He pointed to a big red button with a lock image on it. Glimmer pressed it, and the ship’s ramp receded in and the heavy shutter doors sealed them in, and would seal the void of space out. “Thanks.”

“No problem.” They returned to the couch.

“He's always sore when he wakes up.” He remarked worryingly. The gesture was cute, that little act of kindness surprised Glimmer.

V’s voice echoed through the ship, “Non-clones and gentle-clones please take your seats as we're about to rocket ourselves into the void of space through a wall of fire surrounding the planet, so we're all probably going to die, so say your prayers to whatever deity you believe in, won't matter though because we live in a nightmare world where there truly is no god.” He announced cheerfully. A loud smack could be heard and an “Ouch.” from V.

Hordak’s voice came through, “Ignore him.”

“You’ll get used to that,” Moe spoke up, “That's like Dak’s catch phrase.”

“Is your brother, the bird one, always like that?”

“No, he's usually worse. He's on good behaviour since we have a guest over.”

“Are we- going to experience some turbulence? No offence to your brother but anything he makes is usually held together by duct tape. Are we about to turn into a giant fireball? He loves big fiery explosions.” Glimmer asked concerned, recollecting about the Fright Zone.

“HehHa! Yeah that sounds like Hordak, alright.” He wheeled himself over to a front corner of the ship which had a standing canvas, some small cabinets at the side supposedly housing some art supplies. There was also a small circular window at the corner

framing the view of the outside. “The Annihilation has been through a lot, but you won't find a more reliable (and lucky) ship in The Holy Armada! You won't even feel the take off.”

“How do you know?” Glimmer asked unconvinced.

“Come take a look.” He just pointed to the window. Glimmer, confused, waltzed over to the window, her eyes widened in shock at what she saw. A blue surface, rippling and kicking up as the ship zoomed past; a river, then fields of trees, zipping by. They had already launched. Mount Dryl shrinking into the distance.

They had launched from the side of the mountain, out of the hangar bay doors, cloaked by Entrapta’s holographic disguise field. Soon they surpassed the clouds, and pierced into the atmosphere. For a moment the window became coated in fire and flame. And then it passed, and now the Queen of Light stared out into an endless black void reaching out into infinity. Across the blackness were white speckles; stars, distant suns, sustaining worlds and civilizations all of their own, Etheria a distant speck to them all.

Before they could leave Etheria behind there was one obstacle left; a barrier of warships guarding the planet from the upper atmosphere. An impenetrable wall of hull and fire power. The most powerful warships that side of the galaxy. After the Fall of Prime over a year ago the clones were freed from his control, left to aimlessly wander Etheria - for the first time in their lives without purpose. The clone population was stranded on Glimmer’s magical world, the Princess Alliance weren't about to just let their invaders take back their war machines and leave to who knows where, or worse, turn the weapons back against Etheria. So, at first the warships over Etheria were disabled. But over the following months, as Entrapta established communications with various systems, and rumours began to spill out. A sizeable number of them coming from the clone grapevine. The refugee clones slowly began to form pockets of community around Etheria. The Princess Alliance never stood against it, and even

helped establish those pockets, BrightMoon was always involved in combating homelessness, a programme started by Glimmer's mother, often allowing homeless citizens take shelter and live within the walls of BrightMoon castle.

Within the clone settlements many managed to establish contact with the outside, smuggling becoming a major enterprise. Clones being the main item smuggled off world. Through Hordak various rumours reached her; Word of various larger neighbouring systems eyeing Etheria with watering mouths. Smaller less developed planets often fell prey to larger powers, Glimmer wasn't about to let that happen. And the answer was right under her nose. The clones knew how to operate the worships, of course they'd be supervised by BrightMoon knights, but to her pleasant surprise the clones dedicated themselves to their posts rather quickly and without much convincing or argument. They were desperate for a mission, for a purpose. And so, Glimmer gave them one; Protecting their new home.

Glimmer sighed, "I'm going to be honest I would've felt much better about this if the starships could escort us... No offence, uh…"

"Moe."

"Moe."

"Short for Mosquitor."

"Oh."

"I'm guessing the point of all of this is to stay unseen, and not to attract much unwanted attention."

"It is. Heh, not to mention the reason why we're going to The Council of the Known Universe is to make allies, it'd be hard to do that if we just pulled up with a starship overhead. Don't want to prove the threats and fear mongering rumours correct."

"Didn't you just reason your way out of the predicament?"

“I suppose I did.”

“Also, those aren't starships, heh, you haven't seen a Starship yet. Warships of The Holy Armada are impressive, no doubt about it. But starships are unfathomably enormous. Giant rings, large enough to surround an entire sun, draw power from it, often acting as a shipyard constructing warships for the Prime’s endless conquest. They’re pretty, in a horrifying kind of way.”

Glimmer couldn't even imagine something of that scale. Things like that often made Glimmer put things into perspective of how small and secluded Etheria was. How little she was in the vastness of the cosmos. It frightened her, but she chose not to think about it. But unbeknownst to the Queen that phobia had led her actions subconsciously. Many people are guided by fear, even kings and Queens, whether they know it or not. Glimmer, whether right or wrong, was stepping along the path of fear.

Glimmer’s eyes scoured the dark space and managed to spot a small brush of green among the canvas of black, the only spot of colour in space. “Huh.”

Moe took note of the response, “What? The Velvet Glove? Huh, looks different than when I last saw it, greener!”

“Yeah, that might have been my and my friends’ doing. My… friend, Adora, kinda,” Glimmer scratched the back of her head, “Turned the ship into a giant tree.”

“With many of our brothers still within.”

“Yeah, sorry about thaaAAHHH!” The Queen of Light embarrassingly shrieked as she noticed a third figure standing behind them silently. A man missing his lower jaw. He narrowed his blood red eyes, their wrinkles around his eyes more visible. Glimmer covered her mouth like an old Victorian maiden. “Sorry. My bad. Sorry. Hehe.” Lee seemed unamused. The old clone’s pupils lit up and he turned to Moe. Moe turned back to face him, his pupils lit up too. The two stared at each other without a single

word spoken for a moment or two. Glimmer’s eyes shifted between the two. Are they buffering? What's going on?

Moe returned his gaze to the Queen, “He– ugh, welcomes you on board and wishes you a pleasant stay. And is honoured to be in the presence of royalty, especially one of whom allows us to stay on your world.”

Lee signed with his hands, clearly some sort of sign language, Glimmer managed to make out some of it, but not enough to further the conversation, “I'm sorry I don't know sign language, I- I should but I don't.” She remarked sadly.

Moe translated for his brother, “He just wants to discuss with you- uh- some matters.” He sounded a little awkward and nervous. Lee gave him an angry look for not translating fully. Moe just shrugged.

Outside across the depthless night a streak of light zipped across their view, Hordak spotted it, and moved to tail the craft. It was the decoy ship. As a mediaeval planet-locked civilization BrightMoon had no spaceships with which to cross galaxies. Which was why Adora got Entrapta to step in, and she was all too overjoyed about it. Being the genius she was, Entrapta fished out a crashed Horde ship fixed it up and customised it, now sporting the colour scheme of BrightMoon; purple, pink, and gold, even a painted mural of Glimmer on the hull. You couldn't get more overt than that, if this bait wouldn't work, Entrapta didn't know what would.

That was a lovely day, Entrapta and Hordak made a whole day of it, a date, that was what normal couples did so they thought they'd try it out too. And it was wonderful. Just them working together, bouncing ideas off of each other, problem solving, like two lobes of the same brain working in tandem. It was like a dream. Hordak would cherish this memory for years to come.

Hordak pulled up behind the decoy ship. With a single press of a button the clearance codes were transmitted from The Annihilation to the warships. Then; quiet. This moment was always horrifying. The silence. The wait. Hordak and the rest of the crew knew the codes were correct, Glimmer approved them herself, but each time Hordak's mind briefly flashed to the thought of; What if the codes were wrong? If the warships would open fire, they would be dead in seconds - if not instantaneously vaporised by the battery lasers then they would freeze in the void of space. Seconds ticked away. They waited for the go-ahead; Hordak tense, V, behind him, completely relaxed and indifferent - the fear of death had left the old clone long ago, and then...

A green light lit up on the control panel. And the barricade of warships began to part like the Red Sea. And the tightness in Hordak's chest disappeared and he released a sigh of relief. The two ships bypassed the armada wall and soon after separated, Glimmer watched the bait craft shrink into a dot out of the window and disappear. Soon the armada faded from visibility as well, and they were off on their voyage, no turning back now. Nothing but an endless stretch of darkness.

"Well, I guess there's no going back now." She stepped up to the cockpit and looked on at the eternal night ahead.

V put his feet up on the pilot chair ahead, annoying Hordak, "Why so gloomy your highness. They should call you Gloomer. We're here to have a good time! You know this *is* a road trip, and you know what that means!"

Dak: "No."

Moe: "Oh Prime."

Lee just turned around and left to his room.

V opened a compartment in the chair he was sitting on and pulled out a CD, and practically crawled over Hordak to get to the front control panel and slid the disc into a rectangular device.

Glimmer believed it was called a CD player. And so music began to play from it. A country song come on not that our protagonists knew what that was exactly. The song began:

‘Life is like a road that you travel on,

When there is one day here and then the next day gone,

Sometimes you bend, sometimes you stand,

Sometimes you turn your back to the wind’

Hordak face palmed, unable to escape the sound of the song, trapped in the pilot's seat. He had clearly heard this song a thousand times before. “I can't believe this.”

‘There is a world outside every darkened door,

Where the blues will not haunt you anymore,

Where brave are free and lovers soar,

Come ride with me to the distant shore’

Glimmer bowed her head down and sighed, “This is my life now... for the next week... No going back.” She echoed the words to herself once more. She turned and waltzed back to the couch defeated.

‘We won't hesitate, to break down the garden gate,

There's not much time left today, yeah –

THE DEFECTS, FEATURING QUEEN GLIMMER OF ETHERIA, STARRING IN:

‘L I F E I S A H I G H W A Y !’

‘And I want to ride it all night long.’

End of Act One (of Three)

Chapter 2



Life Is A Highway

Act Two (of Three)

Day Two (of Seven)

The following trip might have been one of the most bizarre experiences in Glimmer's life, which spoke volumes because her life was anything but ordinary. Over the course of the next few days Glim learned things about the clones she never wanted to know or ever thought to ask. For example, when she woke up next morning, she stretched and dozily made her way to the ship's washroom, still somewhat asleep. She yawned, "Oh, 'Dora you won't believe the dream I had, heh, I was sent on a road trip through space with Hordak and a bunch of..." Her eyes widened at the sight inside the washroom, "...clones?"

It was V, of course, 'brushing' his teeth with a... there was no way of putting it otherwise, a knife. Apparently clone teeth were too sharp for regular toothbrushes, and floss, and attracted tartar like cement. "Do you mind?" He mumbled through the foaming toothpaste.

Glimmer was speechless, her eye just twitched. "Yeah, get in line." She turned to the other three up against the wall in a line, waiting impatiently. It was no dream. However, that seemed like a quick stop compared to how long it took Hordak to go through his whole hair dye procedure. It felt like he was in there for hours. However, no matter how much he tried he could never get rid of that one streak of white hair that curled and always fell down against his face. It was the only part of his hair that refused to dye blue. Entrapta often remarked how much she loved it, a little symbol and representation of his imperfection. En always reminded him that she loved all of him just the way he was. But for Hordak it represented a much darker thought, the constant reminder of what lay beneath, of who he 'belonged to'. Constantly attempting to cover up his old life with his new identity, the blue hair, the makeup, the dress, the armour Entrapta and he worked

on together. And yet, every time he looked in the mirror all he saw was his Brother.

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Glimmer had tripped… again, over some discarded armour plates that were just left on the floor (several times mind you), like right now, her face was planted firmly in the floor. A muffled groan escaped her throat, she just... laid there for a moment, and for a moment she contemplated whether she should even get up. What's even the point? Moe wheeled up to the Queen, "Uhmm... are you alright? Uh-" He turned back to face Hordak behind him, "Your majesty? Right?" He checked with Hordak about the terminology, who simply nodded. "Yeah, okay I got that right." Mo murmured that part to himself. Glimmer murmured something incomprehensible. Mo just gave a half smile paired with a confused look, "Alright... Okay… Oh-kay." He hesitated, but turn around, and wheeled himself away giving the Queen some space.

After a moment and a deep sigh, she finally picked herself up, her pinkish-purple, glittery hair all messed up. As she parted her hair and tried to fix it best she could she caught sight of Hordak picking up the littered armour components, like a middle-aged mom picking up dirty laundry after their kids. The comparison was not completely unfounded as the Lord of Metal and Darkness glared up to the dark ceiling where V was lounging about on a bed of loose wires like a hammock, and proceeded to tell him off, "V! What did I tell you about leaving your armour plating on the floor! I'm tired of picking up your life support systems after you! And that goes for everyone in this spacecraft!"

V groaned, closed the book he was reading, and dropped down, "Alright, alright, I'm on it. Geez give over." Moe rolled his eyes, but made sure Hordak didn't see it. The Queen of BrightMoon, her arms droopy by her side and head down low, slowly made her way over to the couch, her place of residence. And fell backwards onto the soft seating, slouching, her royal etiquette, manners, and posture completely gone. In a way it was nice, a little freeing in a way, no longer having to put on a performance for her court and

the public when addressing the masses. She could just relax, I'll be it she would have preferred to relax with her friends, but this was... fine she supposed... her friends. Glim's eyes widened, a light bulb idea lit up above her. The first smile of the day. She reached down for one of her bags and rummaged around inside, and managed to pull out her holo-pad. She could just call Adora, her friends were in arms reach! Perhaps this trip wouldn't be so bad after all, she could just keep to herself – just ask Adora how her day has been, what she's been up to. She so longed to hear her voice. Only day two, and she already missed her, and... and what is happening here? Why was it taking so long? The loading circle icon kept turning and the system of the pad kept chugging, and – nothing. And then the next message that popped up on the screen almost broke her heart – 'No Connection'. Alone once more. She scowled at the box delivering her the message. She almost snapped the pad in half. But she just released the breath she was apparently holding in. And her posture went slack once more.

"You have got to be kidding me."

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Day Three (of Seven)

Glim had little to do within The Annihilation, it very much felt like watching paint dry, and so as you can imagine the walls of the ship weren't entertaining the Queen very much. So, she turned her head to the art corner and watched Moe dance his pencil brush against the canvas. The clone artist had been studying the void of outer space for over an hour now and copying it onto the blank white canvas and proceeded to masterfully depict all of its natural detail and beauty - specks of stars, swirling gas giants, mesmerising planet rings and asteroid belts, colourful beauty of nebulous, and crashing waves of solar oceans at the surface of suns. Every piece was gorgeous, a masterpiece. So pretty it actually compelled her to speak up, "It's gorgeous."

"Hmm?" Moe half turned to her, eyes still on the painting.

“I know you don't think it, but it is, it's amazing. You should be proud of your craft.”

“Hmm.” He nodded slightly, “…Yes. I'm rather happy with it. I think I like it more than my regular work, because not every piece of art has a meaning, but this – this one is different.” The clone remarked with a smile.

“Oh? How so?” She asked genuinely.

“I'm painting these for Drag, you know, poor kid misses so much. He always tries to learn as much as he can about each place we visit. He never knows how much time he has, he hates having these blind spots in his mind... I guess this is my way of trying to help the kid feel... more complete.”

“You seem to be doing most of the heavy lifting in that regard.” Glimmer remarked, clearly seeing Moe as the most well-adjusted person among the clones onboard.

Moe smiled warmly as he turned to view the view outside his window, “I wouldn't be so sure about that.” There, out on the wing of the drop ship, hanging on for his dear life, just out in the coldness of space - was V. A huge toothy semi-psychotic smile on his face joyous face. Good thing clones didn't need oxygen. V reached out and caught in his hand a glistening crystal rock, one of many, out of a field of orbiting similar yet unique crystals. Hordak had passed nearby a ring of a gas giant. V popped the future-to-be gift into a pouch on his belt which was built into his armour. His brothers always collected souvenirs from places they've been to, all the places and wonders Drag missed. The boy loved learning, he had an entire collection of pamphlets and leaflets from all their destinations as proof of that. The boy loved knowing, but could never learn all or enough. And so Drag’s brothers collected souvenir after souvenir, The Defects had no home, no place to call their own, so they chose to build a new foundation, brick by brick.

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Glimmer’s eyes shot open, awoken by noise. It was night, well, what would you consider night in outer space, it was the ‘sleep cycle’ as Hordak put it. Her eyes darted around the setting looking for possible attackers, always vigilant like General Juliet taught her ever since she was a kid. Especially with a handful of untrustworthy clones onboard with her. But she couldn't find them with her sight, they had dimmed the lights in the living room and all had left to their personal bedrooms. Glim didn't know if clones even needed to sleep, or if clones don't but defects do, or maybe they just slept differently. But they had left the Queen to rest in slumber peacefully without distractions. Which was an unexpected, kind gesture. So, who was here with her? That was when she spotted someone, a figure cloaked in shadow. Glimmer scanned it best she could; Pointed ears, red eyes, white hair - definitely clone, but not a familiar one, not one she was used to seeing. She silently and still fully observed the defect without alerting him to her presence – he was holding and staring at one of Moe’s paintings, he was admiring them all and… crying? Gently and quietly sobbing. That was when Glim finally put one and one together, and recognised the clone as Drag, conscious and awake. Probably wondering how much time he had missed this time.

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Day Four (of Seven)

The Annihilation had come to a halt just in time to save Glimmer from madness. She had been walking back and forth along the length of the ship for hours. Bored out of her mind. The fourth day on this journey through space, of being trapped in a metal box surrounded by the void of space. Nowhere to go. Nowhere to explore, just stuck there, with no friends, and no one to talk to. Moe was nice enough, but there was only so much two strangers could talk about. V was chatty, Glim wished he wasn't, he wasn't annoying or snarky, every conversation was just... depressing. Drag was once again unconscious when she woke up in the morning. Hordak was avoiding her, best he could in a confined space like that. And Lee was just… a ghost, she could barely catch a glimpse of him.

Her back and forth pace continued, every few minutes checking her Chronometer, a bracer on her wrist. The device was a glorified watch with a fancy name and an uppercase letter. Hordak had awkwardly handed it to her to aid her in keeping track of time while in between planets, travelling across the dark ocean. She almost wished he hadn't. Not knowing was better. The device displayed several different times on the screen; How much time has passed since the departure from Etheria. The voyages estimated duration. The current time back home. And the time on the nearest planet.

Things were going along normally enough; Moe was painting something on a canvas. Lee was in the small kitchen adjacent to the living room 'talking' telepathically to a very distracted V who was rummaging all throughout the cabinets looking for something.

"Huh." V remarked, pocking his whole head inside the food cabinet.

"What?" "What?" Moe and Lee asked at the same time.

Lee: "Don't-"

Moe: "Jinx."

Lee: "Primedamnit."

V just continued, "I was doing the daily ration measuring check, seeing what I can prep for dinner, and the food amounts are totally off, we're burning through our food way too fast. So, either Drag is going on snack runs while sleepwalking or we have a vermin problem."

Drag remained still and unmoving, a nice, weighted blanket covering him now. The Annihilation was running on autopilot, and Hordak was off in a corner on his own, sat down on the cold floor, charging some device in hand. While Glimmer was marching around, she knew she shouldn't have, but couldn't help but to glance over his shoulder. There he was, the Lord of The Horde, the baron of bedload, the prince of plagues, the dread lord, the

man who once held Etheria in a chokehold – now hunched over on the floor, holo-pad in hand, constantly refreshing the screen, a very similar text box was displayed on the screen – 'No Connection'. He sighed. He was trying to reach Entrapta. But he could not. She was once more an ocean of stars away. The two were torn apart once more. The universe had a diabolical sense of humour. He longed for her voice, so full of passion, excitement, enjoy – she made him feel happy to be alive. At least he had the suit of armour she bestowed upon him, a shield which protected him and soothed his pain. It was a comfort in dark times, a warm reminder that even galaxies away she still managed to protect him. She really was the perfect woman. Hordak smiled at the thought of her. And then once it passed, the bad thoughts returned and the notion of her not being there saddened him further.

There was a sorrow they both shared, for a split-second Glimmer considered connecting with him, but she just shook that absurd notion off.

Suddenly, a beeping came from the ship's cockpit, it seized the attention of both the Princess and the clone Lord as both their heads whipped to the direction of the sound. Hordak left the holo-pad and with a grunt lifted himself up, and strolled to the control panel. Glim followed close behind. "Is that- what I think it is?" She asked slightly on edge.

Hordak hummed as he scratched his incredibly square chin, "Yes. Something just destroyed the decoy ship." He remarked grimly.

"Uh oh." V injected himself into the conversation, "Looks like you've got some fans your majesty."

Glimmer chose to ignored him, "Do we have footage? Do we know if it was the Primusian pirates?"

"We do. But the bait ship was galaxies away, it'll take a few minutes for the footage to travel back to us."

“Do you think the lack of bodies is going to set them off?” Glimmer asked quizzically.

“Hopefully not. In the meantime, while we wait for the transfer, we’ll restock and refuel at the next pit stop. An upcoming gas station.”

Glimmer’s eyes widened, “We're stopping to get out?! As in, to walkabout?” She clapped her hands together, “Yes! I am in, so in! Let's get out of here!... No offence.” She turned back to the rest of the clones.

Moe shrugged, “None taken. V has that effect on people.” He remarked amused.

Hordak looked unsure, “I... I am unsure. Arriving at a fuelling stop with the supposed dead Queen of Etheria – this could unmake the entire mission.” He remarked awkwardly.

Glimmer pondered upon it, after a second the Queen snapped her fingers, “Not if they don't see me.” Hordak quirked his brow, intrigued. Glimmer smiled, and then she disappeared. No woman stood before them anymore.

V exclaimed, “She got raptured!” Lee just slightly smacked his older brother in the back of the head.

Glim, still invisible, sighed, “No. I'm the Queen of Light. I can bend light around my person, making yours truly, invisible.”

“I didn't know you could do that.”

“No. No you did not.”

V remarked, “So, what? When we talk to you we’ll just be talking to thin air?”

“Nothing new for you then.” Moe responded.

“I do not know.” Hordak replied unconvinced.

“I'm the Queen of Etheria, it's not like you can order me around. I'm literally your boss.”

“Fair enough.” He could not argue. He huffed in defeat.

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The Annihilation soon docked at (checkes notes) Bibo’s Gas Stop, a literal embodiment of the term ‘the middle of nowhere’ which was the precise wording used on the comical sign at the port where they docked. The moment the bay doors to the Annihilation opened Glimmer practically leapt out of the ship, far too excited about the grungy, filthy, dirty, greasy, rundown space gas station. But she was just desperate to explore a brand new area other than the metal confined box flying through the void of space she was caged. Even though it was an awful place.

“Sweet breathing room, how I've missed you.” Glimmer reached her hands up into the sky as if worshipping the sun. Not that anyone saw that, luckily for her no one witnessed the embarrassment, once again completely invisible.

Moe rolled down the ramp behind, “Eh- your majesty, were ever you are, please stay nearby, we are meant to be your envoy.”

The rest of the crew marched out behind. Hordak’s head panned upwards to examine the curious energy dome encapsulating the station. “Truly fascinating. An energy field incasing a constantly adapting atmosphere all planted on a rogue asteroid which somehow corrected itself on a Goldilocks zone rotation around the system star. Perhaps an Atmo-Sphere Engine, but how does it atmosphere composition adjust to every individual, fascinating. Perhaps equipped with 360° celestial thrusters that maintain the asteroid within the Goldie- what?” The tone changed quickly to his standard cold harsh demeanour as his head snapped to a chuckling V.

“Fascinating.” V imitated Hordak and cackled.

Hordak rolled his eyes behind the red lenses, his arms and shoulders retreated under his black cape, and turned away from his older brother. “Ugh.” It was clear that being around Entrapta for so long had rubbed off on him. “I'll refuel the ship and get new oxygen canisters for the Queen. Distract yourselves somehow, and do not bother me.” He reached into a pouch on his waist and pulled out a golden credit card, “Go pay for it. And do not attract too much attention, please.”

Before V could snatch the card, Lee took it away and began to walk forwards to the gas station building. With V following close behind, “Alright, but I have to get some extra stuff for the rest of the trip... Don't look at me like that, I do! Scout’s honour!” V crossed his heart, but on the wrong side. Lee just rolled his eyes.

One of the customers looking through the magazine stalls noticed something peculiar; the store doors sliding open without anyone walking in. The alien raised a brow. After a few seconds Moe wheeled in, an awkward smile plastered on his face, he pointed at the sliding doors with his thumb, “Doors, am I right?” And quickly sped off.

Lee waltzed directly to the space-cashier and handed them the card, and raised six fingers up indicating pump six where The Annihilation was docked. The space-teen behind the desk was a bit intimidated by Lee's looming stature, that of a massive rectangle with red eyes. The teen with space-acne swallowed a ball of saliva in their throat, took the card and began the financial transfer. V just stood motionlessly at the cash. Meanwhile, V was rummaging through the store shelves, scrambling and skittering, under his breath chuckling, grabbing various food products off the shelves, huddling a huge massive ball with food against his chest, he could have used a basket or a trolley, but he didn't. He finally arrived at the cash register and dumped the mount of food on the table. “And also this.” V and Lee exchanged looks, “What? Hordak’s girlfriend’s got plenty on that card. I'm sharing the wealth, if anything I'm the good guy here.”
“No.” Lee remarked simply. He pointed his finger back towards the

rest of the store gesturing for V to put back everything he had taken.

Meanwhile, Moe and Glimmer were perusing the small aisles of the rundown store, “Look at all of this neat stuff. Galaxy star maps. Antenna muffs. Space-Barnacle remover acid. Eldrich cosmic horror bobbleheads.” Something else drew her attention, “Oh, they have customizable licence plates for ships, eh, none of them have my name on it.”

“You know you're getting excited over gas station trinkets, right kid?”

“It's not just- it's new. All this is new to me. It's wonderful, there's so much to see, so much that you'll never get to see in your lifetime. So many things pass us by every day. And you won't experience any of it in an office in an ivory tower.”

“Where’s all this coming from all of a sudden? Why so invested?”

“I don't know. Because learning itself, discovery itself is… fun, you know?”

Moe smiled, “Yeah, I do. The beauty of life and all that. I get it, more than you know.”

“It's just nice not being trapped in my office all day every day, flooded by mountains of paperwork, trapped in that damn box hour after hour running an entire planet. I used to go on adventures and quests! And now I just have to watch the world go by from my castle window.”

“...Maybe this will be good for you.”

“The Cthulhu bubbleheads?”

“No, The- What did V call it? The road trip.”

“Huh.”

Moe pulled out a few white and red circular coins, looking like it was made out of white chocolate. He handed the coins to Glimmer. He picked out a licence plate and presented it to the Queen, “How about a souvenir?” The plate read, ‘Glenn’, close enough she supposed. Glimmer gave a small smile and accepted the gift.

Glimmer purchased the souvenir, through Moe of course. She gave Lee the side eye at the space-cash register, it wasn't possible, but it almost seemed like he could see her. They moved on and out. Hordak was hauling new oxygen tanks on board of the ship. “We done?”

“Yeah, put this up somewhere nice.” Moe waved the plate around, Hordak looked at it confused.

“I didn't know you guys needed oxygen.” Glimmer examined the metallic containers.

“We don't. All for you, your majesty.” Hordak replied while wheeling the heavy canisters onboard.

“How thoughtful of you Hordak.” She remarked with a smirk. “Do we... have to go right away? I've barely stretched my legs.”

“Hmm, I don't know, we should maintain our schedule.”

“Could we at least make some other stops along the way? Doesn't it drive you crazy, being trapped inside a metal basement flying through space?” Hordak did not respond. Confined spaces were all he knew; Corridors, ships, pods, labs, the inside was his environment to the point where sunlight at times was an annoyance to him. “Come on come on can't we explore for a bit longer?”

Just then they heard a WHAM, Hordak looked up, his face deflated with tired annoyance. Glimmer turned back to see V come on bursting out from the doors of the gas station, he was carrying the ball of food Lee denied him before, he ran in zigzags, packets of various products slipping through his grasp and falling

to the ground. He looked panicked. “Run! Run!” V ran past Hordak and Glimmer.

Hordak narrowed his eyes, “What. Did. You. Do?”

V furiously tapped the lock button on the ramp bay doors, “Don't be mad.”

“What did you do?!”

“I said don't be mad!”

Suddenly, the doors of the gas station slammed open once again. There was the cashier and what must have been the manager of the store with... a laser shotGUN! The manager cocked the gun. Hordak’s eyes widened, “oh no. Everyone inside! Now!” He rushed everyone onboard, practically picking Glimmer up and hauling her in. BLAMO! Laser gunshot. Moe yelped a bit too loud.

Glimmer quickly ducked and scrambled up the ramp into the drop ship, the Queen rummaged in her pocket, grabbing a handful of cash and flung it out the ship, while yelling , “Sorry!” The ramp clamped shut. Thrusters heated up and blasted out plasma fire, and The Annihilation launched off into the void of space. Hordak and Glimmer snapped their heads over to V and glared at him furiously.

V raised his hands up almost as if protecting his face, “OK, OK, I know, I know- buuut let me make it up to you.” He sneered. Glimmer and Hordak gave each other a silent look, their fury steadied.

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What followed, Glimmer could not comprehend in the moment. The Queen of Light watched the crew of clones unfolded and convert the main living room couch into a dining table. Positioned chairs around for all. Glimmer sat down just as the rest of the crew took their seats, she had taken Drag’s spot. No one

mentioned anything, but Glimmer could feel Lee's cold stare, and it said it all. Glim just sat stiffly, unsure of how to conduct herself in this setting, all the brothers were engaged some casual mundane conversation. She looked off to the side, one of the corners of the drop ship had a little kitchen set up; cabinets, cupboards, a chopping station, a hob, and a sink. It was all impressively compact. Glimmer doubted that any of it was standard of a regular Horde dropship, it must've been custom made. Looked nice, was that oak? Anywho. There was V, cooking. It was a strange sight. And it seemed like she was the only one surprised by this behaviour. Was this his regular routine?

Hordak was sitting across from her; Glimmer had never seen the ex-Lord of the Horde like this, so casual. He wore a simple, loose short sleeved shirt, a long black dress, and his blue curly hair draped over the front of his tired face. His black eye make-up slightly more messy and worn. His red lenses off, his red irises in the open. The warlord that almost conquered her world, once feared, was now hunched over a holo-pad on the table. He kept refreshing the device, that same loading circle that taunted her did so to him. He looked tired and frustrated. Not knowing why the device was not working. A low grumble escaped him, almost a purr.

"Here we are!" V announced as he placed a plate in front of Glimmer, "Chow down." He gave a toothy smile, it was genuine, but Glimmer felt a little unsettled none the less. She just awkwardly stiffly smiled at V, V responded by widening his grin even further. Glimmer tried to outdo him but her smile wobbled. "So... What's this? Poison?" Glimmer quirked a brow.

"It's caviar. Zenbaaran roast meat. Faybian ursa-berry jello. Oombackis rice and veggies. Defrosted crockets."

"From?"

"The freezer." He remarked matter of factly, then his voice peaked again, "Bone apple sit!"

“That's not- ugh” Did Lee just sigh telepathically? Can you even do that?

“The stuff you stole? Was food. For dinner?... you cook? Dinners?” Glim couldn't hide how flabbergasted and surprised she was by this simple concept. She just couldn't picture a clone doing something so bland, mundane, and... and kind for his ‘family’. Going about it the wrong way, but with good intention, maybe. “Not just dinners. It should last as the rest of the journey. Plus, I slapped some cash on the counter, fake money, sure,” he shrugged, “but still.” V sat down without a plate in front of him, and kicked his feet up on the table.

Which Hordak immediately swiped off the table and remarked scowling, “No feet on the table.” His tone shifted from stern to lax and soft, “V may be a loudmouth moron with a weird nose, but if there's something he knows how to do, it's cook.”

“I'll take it. And no electronic devices while we're eating dinner at the dinner table, young man.” V marked to Hordak about the holo-pad on the table. Hordak grumbled, but retreated the pad off the table. V leaned back against his chair.

“And nothing for you?” Glim asked the vulture-like man.

“Don’t care much for it. Not my thing.” V shrugged.

The clones dug in. Glimmer’s eyes scanned the table, still slightly unsure, only then did the Queen realise how hungry she was. She had poor experience with clone dinners, but... the food did look good. She picked up the utensils shaped like a crescent moon, and scooped up some of the rice and veggies, and... Hordak wasn't wrong, V really was a good cook. And soon she couldn't stop herself, the plate was cleaned within minutes, one of the best meals she had in a long while.

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V honked forcefully slamming down against the air horn on the steering wheel. He was furious. The elder clone rolled down the

side window of the cockpit, the atmosphere bubble expanded outward, allowing for V to poke his head out and wave his fist angrily at the traffic up ahead. The Annihilation was stuck in space traffic. Spaceship lanes were created to ensure safe and organised space travel, especially in heavily populated systems. The Defects were now about to enter The Black Donut System, a system circling an infant black hole, a roundabout which utilised gravitational slingshot momentum allowing bypassers to reach neighbouring systems faster. But there was still one obstacle ahead of The Defects, the traffic jam, but that was due to the border control ahead. V yelled furiously at the price of the boarder crossing, "Fifty Romulaks?!?! Where are we crossing over to?! Terabithia?!" Pricey costs these days, capitalism, I tell ya.

The only reason V was even allowed to sit in the cockpit seat was because Glimmer and Hordak had retreated back into the ship's belly into Hordak's room who had excavated a set of table chess. Which was built into a small circular table located in Hordak's room, he had picked it up a few missions ago from a pawn shop on Autolycus III, he thought it might have been... Fun. Hordak and Lee partook in a game or two from time to time. He had awkwardly asked the Queen if they were interested in a game. Glim just kind of shrugged and agreed, there wasn't much to do, but she wanted to kill some time.

When the chess was activated a board rose up and divided into four layers one levitating over the other. The chess pieces were divided via colour coding – Glimmer's pawns where pink and Hordak's were blue. The pawns hovered over the various chequered panels, all shaped as teardrops, constructed from the same crystal-like material. Glimmer's teardrops where upright with the tail of the drop pointing skyward while Hordak's were pointed downward. The crystals were dispersed across the boards, they were far into their game by this point. The Queen and the Lord faced off, and were sat on opposite ends, they were both leaning back on their respective armchairs, too afraid to get too close, keeping each other at an arm's length, only getting close to move their pawns.
They remained silent for most of the time, until her eyes shifted

up from the miniature battle to analyse her opponent, and after a moment she broke her silence, “So, you've been avoiding me.”

“No, I... no... I simply assumed you'd prefer space in such a limited location.”

“How thoughtful of you.” She remarked sarcastically.

“If you so wish I could leave you to your own devices, and we may cease this game.”

“No, no. I don't mind. It's not like I have anything else to do... I've noticed the holo-pads aren't working.”

“Yes. There appears to be a technical malfunction, though I am unable to discern the cause or how to mend it. I can only hope that my Beloved has more luck on her side back at Dryl.” He sighed resigned, “I wish I was smarter. Everything always seems to hinge on her to be fixed. I wish I could lighten the weight on her shoulders.”

Glimmer moved her pawn forward thoughtfully, “Yeah. I... know what you mean. There are days when I wish I could do more for Adora, help each other shoulder the burden, share the weight of the world.”

“Hmm, so... you and She-Ra Adora...”

“What?! Who told y- What’d you mean?”

“My apologises, I was led to believe that you two were together – romantically. The Warrior of Greyskull was quite open and forward about the subject matter.”
She hid her face behind her opened palms, “Oh Adora…” She looked up to Hordak, “Do NOT disclose this to anyone.”

“I doubt anyone would lend me their ear, or that I know anyone to tell such things to. Why do you see She-Ra Adora’s openness as an issue?”

"It's not an issue! It's just- ugh- it's just there's so many rumours already, the royal court and the public can be exhausting and intrusive. I just- I just want to spare her from- from the fate of being my partner. Keeping us a secret makes everything simpler."

"Mmm." He understood. He related. He would hate prying eyes disturbing the little world Entrapta and he had built for each other in each other's embrace.

"You probably wouldn't understand."

"…Probably."

"…I miss her so much."

"That- I understand all too well."

"…Any update about the baitship?"

"Yes. Our suspicions were correct; Primus pirates."

"Guess they'll have quite the shock when they see the presumed dead Queen talking at an intergalactic conference in a few days."

"That would be the most preferable outcome… What are you planning on saying at the summit? Have you a speech prepared?"

"Don't remind me. I've had to deliver plenty of speeches for an entire Queendom, I'd like to think that over time I've gotten better at it. But I don't know, I've never spoken in front of so many eyes. Full galaxies. The fate of Etheria in my hands. I've been revising, looking over my queue cards for days now… I still fumble the words sometimes."

Hordak felt the need, the desire, to add something profound, "In my experience the key to delivering the most effective speeches is emotion; like when I delivered the Horde Manifesto atop Stinger Cliff when I rallied the forces of Scorpion Hill and

forged the Etherian Horde on that day and... I- I just realised that might not be... the best example, hmm…”

“Yeahhh. Emotion. Anything else?” She asked with a half-smile.

“Well...” He searched his mind, “I usually left the public dealings to Shadow Weaver.” Glimmer looked like she was about to retreat from the conversation, Dak attempted to salvage it somehow, “However, confidence is key. You must believe in what you're speaking about, and you must show the crowds that you believe, that is where the confidence comes from. But honest passion won't carry you through you're talking to bureaucrats and politicians after all. You must tell them more that they want to hear, offer them something you're in possession of, as far as we know, the only magical world, the holy Armada of Prime under your control. You hold the cards, do not let them forget that.” That earned a smile from Glimmer. Hordak moved one of his pawns down from the top board down onto a pink pawn on a board underneath. Hordak claimed another piece.

“Yeah... I won't.”

“A lot is riding on this conference. We as a planetary species are behind on the evolutionary curb. Being trapped in Despandos, the cataclysm, sent us back. And now those bigger empires are circling like sharks. The universe only ever sees us as a collectible to be owned. We're always the small guy, well I'm tired of that. I'm tired of being small, at the mercy of others. It's time we change that. We hold the cards.”

Hordak realised that he might have gone a bit too far in the wrong direction with his advice, “Uh, yes, but be careful, your majesty. Power has tainted love to your hearts.”

“That's a bit hypocritical coming from you, isn't it?” That had Hordak return to silence, “What if it happens again? Some 2-bit visionary coloniser decides to come over for a spoonful of sugar and conquest. What chance do we have? What if we fail the next time? We need to be ready, we need to show the rest of the

universe that we mean business. And we need allies for that.” Glimmer leaned in and reached out for a pawn on the lowest layer and moved it forward two spaces attacking Hordak’s piece and taking one of his pawns. Once defeated the teardrop faded to a dark grey. “So four days on the road now so to speak.” Hordak replied with a ‘hmm’ his way of acknowledging what she said wordlessly, not knowing how to respond, he didn't have the experience to socialise with people properly. “I think I've started to understand you all. Moe's the artistic, carefree spirit, who just wants to enjoy the beauty of the world like Peri. Drag seems to be an innocent kind soul, the heart of your merry band, the glue, kind of like Bow. V has a hard time showing how much he cares, but he does, sort of like Mermista, but don't tell her that, she'd be furious. But Lee, he seems to like to keep his distance, and give me furious stares from afar. Something you want to tell me?”

Hordak rolled his eyes and sighed annoyed, “I assure you he does not dislike you. My older brother... struggles to articulate some… issues he has.”

“Such as?”

He had caught another sigh escape his lips, he massaged the bridge of his nasal cavity, “Lee is concerned with the concept of nation building. After the Fall of Prime, your world became a refuge for our people. Lee wishes for Etheria to become our home, and a safe haven for all clones. He's been growing frustrated with how slowly it's been moving forward.”

“Slowly? In the past few months haven't we allowed you and your brothers to stablish government communities? Pass clone rights. Dryl helped clone settlements gain fresh water, electricity, everything. The Alliance has supported the clone communities even through all the unrest, and all the demands for your head.”

“The Alliance has not supported anything, they have remained quiet, in order not to enrage your supporters. When the hive mind fell, those who were present at Etheria where free to explore their true selves, live in freedom, comprehend the concept of freedom.

But the horde was vast, countless of my brothers across the cosmos suddenly without a voice in their head, lost. Some must not even know Prime is dead. We could-”

“Bring them to Etheria? And how many exactly is ‘countless’, Hordak? Etheria can't support millions of refugees, the overpopulation would be devastating.”

“The Horde is no more, all Horde infrastructure, the commanding figure gone, these clones are left amidst a cosmos that despises them.”

“Rightfully so.”

“This is about saving lives! Etheria is the only semblance of safe haven for clones in a universe that wants to eliminate them! And overpopulation is not an issue, the entire Etherian population only takes up 27% of the planet, centralised on a single continent.”

“Which is supposed to mean what? That one day you can outnumber us 5 to one? Surround and replace us?”

“Replace?! A man who needs a suit of armour to get out of bed will replace you? A demigod elitist who only cares for her own domain?! There was a reason why Scorpion Hill turned so swiftly against you and the core Queendom's!”

Glimmer stood up abruptly, she slammed her hands against the board toppling a handful of pawns. “You wanna try that again?” Her eyes flashed a pinkish-purple, and the lights within the room began to flicker and go haywire, “You think you know me, but you're just a pathetic recluse, you don't know anything.”

“I know enough. I know that you have a container of Etherian soil to maintain your powers, to eliminate us in case we become an inconvenience to you.”

“You- You went through my things?! I have to defend myself against a group of monsters somehow! What else can I expect from a machine created for conquest!?”

“You think you know me.”

“I know enough.” Glimmer took off her mother's earring which always hung from her left ear. The last piece of her mother she could physically still hold onto, and from a position where her pawn once dude, she used the earring to knock Hordak’s king over.

Glimmer marched out of the room, with the doors sliding closed behind her. Hordak sighed with the full force of his misery. He just sat in his chair, his head bowed, for a few silent moments. “That went poorly.”

A voice sounded from inside his head. Hordak jumped, “Ahhh!” He turned in panic around to see Lee standing behind him, “How?! - How did you - where did you c- there aren't even any shadows in this well lit room!”

Lee wordlessly walked over to Glimmer’s opposing chair and sat down. Lee observed the chess board, coming in mid battle, a conflict unfinished. “I am disappointed in you boy.” Hordak rolled his eyes, here we go again. “Do not roll your eyes at me! I am unable to voice my thoughts, my opinions, my wishes and my troubles. Is it too much to ask for my more able-bodied brothers to help me voice my mind?”

“No, brother, but I- I tried, but I- I do not possess... the vernacular to convince her to aid us.”

“Enough excuses, boy. The fate, the well-being of our race is at stake. We stand at a crossroads. And you are the only one who can bring about positive change for all our brothers. You are family to royalty, you are a leader of men, your name it means something here, or it can. You have the power to influence… to save us… do you... do you understand that?”

“I- Of course I do, I just can't-”

“No, boy. No more excuses. Put in the effort. The people of the Queen seem to respond to emotion and openness – appeal to her

with emotion and openness. Show her that we are people, that we are not monsters. Show her our true nature."

"…I understood. I will attempt to- No, I will… I will."

"Good," Lee smiled, "That is good, kindly brother." His hand hovered down to the several pieces on the floor, and picked them up, "Now then, shall we have a friendly game?"

"I have yet to beat you."

"You will get there soon enough, practice hones skills."

"My scientific theory is that you simply enjoy to watch me loose."

"Hehm, non-sense."

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"Keith, I'm pregnant."

"I knew it." V remarked aggressively at the reveal taking place on the TV screen – another one of V's soap operas, as obnoxious as they were the others had to unfortunately admit it was entertaining television. The thing was V wasn't even watching the screen, he was too busy studying the inside of one of the cupboards in the kitchen corner.

Glimmer stormed out of Hordak's chamber room, of course there was nowhere for her to go on such an enclosed space. She stormed past Moe who's greeting went unnoticed, and she made her way to the couch where her luggage rested. From her bag she pulled out a glass orb containing a sample of earth from the grounds of BrightMoon, she closed her eyes and focused her mind, channelling the magic of her home planet through her body like a conductor and thusly materialised a pink bubble around herself covering the couch and isolating herself from the rest of the ship.

“Sooo, does that mean... no more TV time for us?” V muttered while his head was still stuck in the kitchen cupboards looking for something.

“Guess so. That's just the effect Hordak has on people... I know I say this enough times to make it a catch phrase, but what are you doing?” Moe asked confused at his brother's continuous rummaging in the cupboards, and cabinets. The kitchen corner was a mess. Again.

“I told you, I've been checking our food rations, and unless Drag is waking up in the middle of his sleep cycle and midnight snacking, there's definitely something here with us.”

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That damn loading icon. That spinning circle at the centre of the blurry screen had been taunting her for days now. She got angry just by looking at it. She groaned to herself, facepalming and slowly dragging her palms down against her face, leaving the holo-pad on her lap. “I hate this place. Oh, I hate everything.” She was alone, that was what she believed. Utterly alone. And then-

“It can't be that bad.” The Queen's eyes widened, and her hands parted, that voice! So familiar and sweet! Glimmer looked down to see the smiling face of her partner. Adora looked a little rough around the edges, but even with scratches and scrapes and a little bit of dirt on her she still looked radiant and godly, and beautiful.

Glimmer almost teared up, “Oh my stars, it worked! You're here! I tried calling you for days! You wouldn't pick up! I was so worried! I missed you so much, Dodo.”

Adora's eyes rolled upwards to confront the ceiling in order to avoid Glimmer’s face, her face turned to the side, and a warm blush rushed across the valkyrie’s cheeks, “I missed you too, firework.” The most powerful woman in the universe, she could easily face off against the greatest monsters in universe, yet she

often struggled to accept compliments and face her lover when smiling. That was Adora. “I wish I could kiss you right now, you wouldn't believe the day I've had.” She remarked brushing a strand of golden hair out of her face.

“Tell me about it. But I don't get it, why couldn't I reach you?”

“From what I understand, and mind you I'm no Entrapta I clock every fifth word she says, is that we were out of range, that off world mission I told you about? The signal from your pad could only reach to Etheria, not beyond it.”

“That explains that I suppose... so? How was your day?” Glimmer asked in a mundane fashion.

That drew a chuckle from Adora, “Oh let me tell ya those suspicions were correct. Turns out a version or a fraction of LightHope transmitted itself to an off-world facility in order to reconstruct a backup of herself and launch a counterattack against Etheria to reclaim it. Good thing Entrapta caught the signal and went with us. Otherwise, we could have been caught completely off guard.”

“Ennie went with you?”

“She did. She thought having a project on her hands would help her get her mind off of... ‘Things’. She's having the time of her life; the entire moon was like one massive server room, she'll be sifting through First Ones files for months.”

“And how are you doing?” Glimmer asked worried, “I know it can't be easy around all that First Ones stuff.”

“Oh, it's alright I've come to terms with all that long ago. I'm not my ancestors, all I can do is move forward and be better, and hopefully undo all that was done. They can't use me as a weapon now.”

“Tell me- tell me about home. What's going on with all of you guys? What's new?”

“Haha, oh, where to start? Frosta has been missing you, she's trying to keep everyone in line for you until you get back. Peri's been spearheading the whole reforesting initiative, alongside Scorpia. The Fright Zone has never been so... pleasant? Bright and colourful. Vibrant and full of life. Flowers the likes of which you have never seen! Scorpia’s rallying ex-Hordesmen to cooperate in the new government. Meri and Seahawk have accidentally burned down another ship port, it's really becoming a problem, really. Bow’s getting his dads to actually converse with BrightMoon’s educational sector and shake hands with your dad starting up a new initiative to improve education programmes across all the Queendom's. Spinnerella and Netossa are dealing with some trouble in their court, some family member of Spin’s accused Net of marrying into the throne and money for greedy and selfish gain. Spin is more or less trying to hold Net back from pummelling them into the ground. And Catra, she's been quiet, finding herself, working on her anger, re-connecting with the whole MagiCat Queendom at the core of the planet thing. It's a whole thing. And you? What's new with you?”

“Ugh.”

“Oh, that sounds good.” Adora remarked sarcastically and playfully.

“I don't know how long I can hold out here. These- Hordak is driving me crazy! I- I just don't know why you thought this was a good idea, Dodo. Why do you have so much faith in him?”

Adora paused for a moment, her eyes shifted as her thoughts tried to form themselves into sentences in her mouth, perhaps this was the first time she had spoken her thoughts out loud on this subject, “Well... he saved me, Glim. When I was a child. This seemingly heartless, pure evil, warlord with no concept of what a child is, the hand of an evil God, found a crying infant in a field, he wasn’t looking for it, didn’t know what it was, and yet, he chose to pick me up and bring me to safety – this crying baby, brought it with him. I wondered why. If not for him, I wouldn't have made it. Not me... not us… not anything – no universe

saved. All because of a single random act of kindness from a stranger. There- There must have been some good in them."

"Heh, that's you to a tea – that endless belief that people can be good. It could be the most wonderful attribute about you." The Queen of Light smiled dreamfully. "I, sometimes, wish I could be like you." She admired her girlfriend with stars and sparkles in her eyes.

"I'd argue you are. I mean you trusted me, a Horde trooper, and here we are."

"I suppose you're right."

"Hey, look, Entrapta and the rest of us will board a ship and we'll B-line it straight to you, but it'll just be a while. But... please give him a chance, the way you gave me." Glimmer contemplated it, not that she really had any choice, "Plus, I need someone to walk me down the aisle aaand it's slim pickings."

"Hehehe, wow, you're not walking down the aisle, I'm walking down the aisle, I already promised my dad." She remarked smiling.

"We'll arm wrestle for it." Adora always somehow managed to lighten the mood and lift spirits.

"Somehow that seems fixed." Glimmer remarked with a smile as she reached into one of her bags in search of a sandwich to nibble on, and was met with in opposing nibble. Glimmer yelped, the bubble around her burst, and Glim leapt up off the couch. The Queen flailed her right arm in an attempt to shed something of her person – some mass which had bit down on her middle and index finger. The jaws of the attacker relented, and they fell back on the couch.

"What! What is it!? I can't see! Glimmer!" Adora exclaimed from the screen of the holo-pad. The clones all gathered disturbed by the commotion. They all circled the couch, in an effort to apprehend the rodent which somehow managed to sneak

onboard. Then the said rodent poked their head out from the cover of the couch cushions, his face still dirty from the sandwich he chowed down on. And they were all met with a familiar set of yellow eyes as well as a pair of chubby cheeks and messy curled grey hairs.

V smiled a toothy grin as he picked up his only nephew, “It's the boy!”

Imp had somehow snuck aboard. He gave a little burp and wiggled his little baby feet. He had no idea how much trouble he was in.

The End of Act Two (of Three)

Chapter 3

Chapter Summary

> Sooo, I know I'm late, but better late than never right? In the bittersweet honour of She-Ra leaving Netflix I figured I'd finally stop procrastinating and finish the Life Is A Highway series from the previous She-Ra Big Bang. All the love to the Crew-Ra and this community :) And of course, as always, the special art made for this story specifically is by the amazing and wonderful @themazziah @cosmiccanineart show them some love. Forever honoured by their decision to work alongside me on this one, I'm just sorry it took so long to get out. (i had it finished and all written out in my notebook for a while now it's the transcribing and editing on digital that takes me so long) Hope you all enjoy.

Life Is A Highway

Act Three (of Three) - The Long-Forgotten-Awaited Finale!

"Do you have any idea how much trouble you're in, young battling?" Hordak was losing his mind, and judging by the fact that Glim and the rest of the crew could hear him as clear as day, even through the walls of his personal chamber. And the other goobers were, of course, eavesdropping on the scolding. I mean wouldn't you? Ears pressed against the doors leading to Hordak's room. V almost fell inward when Hordak swung open the door, fully aware of their presence. He replied only with a glare, and the crew quickly returned to minding their own business. Except of course Imp himself who fluttered out of the doorway over Hordak's head, happy as a woodchipper. The baby had not a worry in the world. Imp had landed in the arms of V, his favourite uncle, and the troublemaker's biggest supporter.Those two facts might have been linked. "Do you have any idea how dangerous these missions are? How much danger you're in?! There's- There's a thousand things that could go wrong; a leak in the fuel line can cause the engines to vaporise us, the hull puncture can expose us

to the deadly void of space, or worse, some crazy can capture you and experiment and dissect you!”

The small battling just pouted, looking so cutely angry. He folded his little arms.And stuck his tongue out. It was clear that the boy wasn't taking this too seriously. And in a sense, he was right. Hordak wasn't really angry, he was concerned. Imp knew his father couldn't really get angry at him. It was almost physically impossible for him. Hordak sighed, massaging the bridge of his naval cavity.

V, as always, came to the tiny hybrid’s side, “Oh, come on, Dak. Go easy on the kid. Kid’s a rebel just like his … What's it called?”

“Uncle?” Glim suggested.

V snapped his fingers. “That's it, thank you. He's got a good influence. That being, at least he won't end up like a wuss, like ‘his old man’.

“Why do you always take his side?”

“Hey, we flyers gotta stick together.” The vulture-like clone raised his hand and high-fived the little stowaway. “Plus, if you ask me, it's about time, the little guy needs the experience, he'll need it if he ever wants to be a capital-D Defect, like us.”He winked. And Imp seemed excited.

But Hordak wouldn't have it. “He's not like us! And he never will be!” That sounded harsher than he had intended. That one seemed to hurt the boy. A painful and sad expression graced the boy’s face, which he turned away from Hordak, hiding it against V's shoulder. Hordak could hear a light sniffling coming from them. Their poor small spy. He quickly attempted to correct his mistake. “I simply meant you already have a role - by Entrapta’s side. She needs her helper, someone by her side to not make her feel alone. Does she even know you're here? Do you know how worried she must be right now?”

Imp still did not answer and kept facing away from their guardian. V spoke for the mute boy. “You've said enough, kid. Let's cool off a bit.” He took Imp with him over to the ship’s cockpit. Hordak bowed his head in shame and guilt. He wordlessly returned to his chambers. Moe followed behind them, disappointed. Lee returned to his quarters having left nothing to say. And so that left… Glimmer.

What was she to say? This wasn't her world. She didn't belong here. She had no stakes in this, nothing to relate to. This wasn't her problem. Had no need to get involved. They weren't even people.

Then why did she venture forward, once again pressing her ear against the door, invested. She could hear Moe questioning Hordak. “What was all that about?” The wheelchair bound clone spoke with a mix of disappointment and anger.

“I didn't- You know what I meant.”

“Enlighten me.”

“What I said was true. I do not want him to be like me in any sense. I just want them to be safe, home, with my beloved. Far away from this; the pain, the misery, the servitude. Everything I do- Everything I have done is to make sure he gets to live a free life. I want him to live up to be something more than a soldier. Or a pawn, or a servant. A monster. This side of me is what I want to keep away from him. This-- this place is the worst of me. He's a clever boy, doesn't have to end up like me. He should be more like Entrapta.”

“You can't keep the boy away from his people and from his creator.” Moe placed a hand on Hordak’s shoulder assuringly. “He is of two worlds, and you've told him to reject one of his halves.”

“How could I not? What is there to take pride in? What have we brought upon the world but blight?”

“For starters?: Imp.” Well played. Hordak had no response to that. Disappointed in no one but himself. Clearly defeated. “But there is more to the venom, isn't there?...The boy… He's defective, isn't he?”

“...” Hordak posture deflated. The air escaped his lungs, words clearly failing him. There was a painful lump in his throat. “Modulok ran a diagnostic on him at our request. His cough wasn't going away. He couldn't sleep, even with us. I feared the worst. Mode all but confirmed it. Claimed there was a high possibility of him developing defection. Due to me being the gene donor. I had hoped that Shadow Weaver’s DNA would have stabilised the genetic structure. But it seems that we both pretended to be stronger than we were. Her magical malformations could have unforeseen consequences on his health. Some we might not be prepared for. But he can't be. He can't be like me. He has to be stronger. I couldn't have passed this evil onto him.”

“He isn't infectious, D. You won't save him by pushing him away - isolating him. He feels it. You know, the hate. You hate your own defects and it's no mistake that it extends to Imp. He feels it. Show him otherwise. Treat him like we wanted to be treated by our creator.” Moe spoke wisely.

Glimmer was taken out of her thoughts and her eavesdropping as the Annihilation shook, the metal panelling rattled violently. Turbulence… in space? The Queen retreated back to the cockpit where V had taken helm of the controls, which normally Hordak wouldn't let him near, but the autopilot was doing most of the work. She wondered if he was aware that it was on. The Queen of Light wibble-wobbled her way up to the would-be pilot, struggling to keep her balance, she stumbled upon the chair. There was Imp laying down on his belly on top of the dashboard, his head hidden behind his chubby arms, his arrow headed tail wagging angrily. Mad but adorable. Glimmer took a risk and scratched his little head. Like you would a kitten. “Hey little guy.” Sigh. “Know how you feel.” She turned to V. “So what's up with all the turbulence, you know, in the void of space. Struggling with space-parallel-parking?”

“Not afraid of a little crushing force of gravity are you, Madam Royal pants?” V didn’t even turn to look at her, quite possibly because due to his radar-like head he had a perfect mapping of the 3D space around him. He literally had eyes in the back of his head.

“Not if you reassure me nicely that we won't die a horrible, horrible death in a vast nothingness where our loved ones will never find us.”

“Heh, that’d be nice.”

“So?”

“Eh, nothing to be losing sleep over, perfectly normal occurrence, just managed to finagle out of the space traffic jam. And we've started to circle the black hole which we’ll use to slingshot ourselves to cut down on our journey time in half. What's not to love? Perfectly safe.”

“Oh my moons, maybe Hordak had a point.”

“About what?” V replied with an ire of anger, something she hadn't seen from him before. No joke, no ridicule, no mockery. For the first time on this journey, and maybe in his whole life, he sounded genuine. “That we’re in danger? As if there is a place in this joke of a universe that's safe for us, the boy’s life was going to be a struggle from the moment he was born. If his body won't fail him, the universe is going to hunt him down. He needs to prepare for it, and he needs to know that he's not alone.”

Glimmer couldn't have imagined what that would be like. She had, of course, issues with her teleportation and the glitches. But her position as royalty often afforded her certain advantages in life. “That's quite sweet, V, in a way.”

“...Yeah, well, it's like I said, flyers gotta stick together.”

Day Five (of Seven)

The next night felt tense, she could feel it. Glimmer stood up all night texting with Dora, filling her in on what had transpired after she hastily disconnected after Imp's surprise entrance. Adora wrote how Entrapta was now more at ease now that she knew where Imp was and that he was safe with Hordak. Glimmer even sent her some cute pics of the snoring imp at her request.

Adora asked about how the plan was going, very clearly worried about her. She was so sweet. Glim gave her a good big smile and attempted to reassure her that everything was going according to plan, as far as they were aware. The recording of the bait ship's destruction had finally arrived. Strange it took so long, but Glimmer was no super-scientist so she didn't pretend to understand it. The footage was more corrupt and glitched than they had anticipated. It must have been damaged in the explosion as the beginning of the footage was scrambled and completely missing. But the rest was as clear as day. An unmarked Primusian pirate vessel opening fire on a decoy ship, annihilating it. They scoured the wreckage, seemingly satisfied with the lack of life. And saluted in celebration, proud of taking a life. It was sickening. They returned to their vessel and swiftly departed.

But at least it put her mind at ease with having no need to expect an assassination at every turn. It seemed that the worst she had to deal with was family drama, which unfortunately hit a little too close to home. She mentioned it to 'Dora, who in turn relayed it over to Entrapta. Who was worlds away on a mission to contain a dangerous rogue AI. But she, from what she could tell, didn't sound too worried.

Hordak and Imp had a tendency to bicker. They were brothers after all, but they always made-up in the end. There was nothing in the world that they loved more than each other. The boys were going to be okay. And you know what? The girl wasn't wrong. She knew her boys. As Glimmer pretended to be asleep, coated in layers of blankets hiding her among the couch. She managed to catch a figure exiting the chess room and making their way quietly through the dark so not to awaken Imp and curled up around the small battling, on the blanketed floor, the boy in turn nestling into

the older clone, into their chests. Soothed by Hordak's mechanical heartbeat. Both producing synchronised chirping. So it turned out they did sleep after all.

Glimmer followed suit. She needed some more shut eye too. She typed up her goodbyes and good nights to Adora, who herself returned with the sweetest toothrotting pleasantries. I'm proud of you, I miss you, I love you. Hugs and kisses. Smiling face emoticons etc. etc. She loved her so much.

Day Six (of Seven)

Morning brought its own new problems. They were running low on fuel, even though they had just refuelled. Hordak, being the mechanic of the crew, quickly caught on to the fact that something was off. He checked the fuel tanks. They were almost empty. However, there was a saving grace just up ahead, how convenient, they had just enough to make it to the next gas station, but no further, at 'Glippo's Pit Stop'. Deja vu much?

And there was one more thing Hordak found; 'condensed air', he called it. Invisible substance that fills ship tanks under guise of fuelling. Undetectable unless visibly seen. Often used by law enforcement operatives to subtly cage in criminals on the run, which begged the question; Were they being hunted? Hordak dispatched The Defects the moment they landed on the small, strange planetoid to track down the owner and ask some questions, which Lee and V, of course, did very gently, by holding them up against a wall, interrogating them with a variety of sharp implements. Hordak himself chose to remain on board with Imp. Partaking in some delightful colouring and drawing on the floor of the Annihilation, with some emergency crayons stashed away under the floorboards by V for just this occasion. The old clone often held up a veil of indifference, but for the little boy, he was a big ol' mush. Turned out Hordak's suspicions were true after all, after a little chat with their new friend Glippo. He revealed everything, turns out, would you believe it, Bibo and Glippo were brothers and owners of a family business, and racketeers, only refuelling passing ships enough to reach the others' gas station.

No further. Business was booming. The brothers may have been frauds, but they did not seem to be in league with any malignant third party. But the crew were still sitting ducks. Easier to track and launch an assault against. They needed to get moving up in the sky as soon as possible. But first The Annihilation had to be refuelled properly, to which Hordak attended personally.

After a few pouty looks from Imp Hordak sighed and gave him the permission to go out and explore, and play around on the new world. This, in fact, might have been the battling's first alien world, first time away from his Etherian birthworld.

The impling seemed to be a little uncertain and cautious of setting foot on the foreign world, stopping at the end of the ramp, curiously eyeing the green grass a step away. But after Hordak gave them a reassuring smile and a nod, the boy happily jumped out and began to practically roll around in the fields, getting covered in grass and dirt all the same. Bath time later that day was going to be a nightmare. The smile faded just as fast as it appeared on Hordak's face to make sure Glimmer wouldn't catch it, which she, of course, did. But as a gesture of solidarity she volunteered to look after the kid. "I'll keep an eye on him." Partially also looking for any excuse to get off the ship to stretch her legs. Hordak simply answered with one of his patented grumbles.

The hours that followed felt almost surreal. It was genuinely a lovely time. Way bigger responsibility laid out their looming in the future, but for just a little bit the Queen of Light was able to free her mind from the stress and worry, just a little. Playing tag, hide and seek, catch, and anything else that came mind, with the little rascal, though occasionally stopping him from chomping down on several flowers and butterflies. Otherwise the day was full of happily frolicking through the beautiful green grass fields speckled with colourful, vibrant flowers and flora. This strange planetoid was so captivating and fascinating. Glimmer would later on find out that the world had a total of twenty-six seasons which cycled in and out every day. It was magnificent to watch the warm, sunny clear skies shift into cool breezes, gorgeous yellows and

oranges falling from the trees to the pretty dusting of white snow, which in turn would disappear only moments later. Moe had managed to capture its transition on one of his canvases. He had set up some lawn chairs for them to rest on. He offered one to Lee, who silently denied it and proceeded to retreat to the top of their ship, where he assumed the role of lookout.

But little did they know what was transpiring on the other side of the solar system, where poor Bibo was being held up in an interrogation of his own, but far less pleasant if you'd believe it. By some unfavourable characters, but there was one thing that saved the man's life; the manifest logs he kept of every craft that docked, fueled and left the station. And wouldn't you know it he also knew where they were all going, his brother's rest-stop. The aggressors thanked the owner with a wicked smile, and they were on their way, leaving dear Bibo's body behind them.

Systems optimal. Architecture intact. Fuelling uninterrupted and no foreign bodies detected. Hordak double, then triple checked all of The Annihilation's facets, and everything seemed green, and proper, thank Pri-- he caught himself mid-thought-process. Force of habit. There was still much to unlearn, hopefully sooner rather than later. All was taken care of, so then there was nothing else to do but sit down and wait. And so he did, resting his sore back and joints, endlessly reminding him of his physical impairments. Through their unending screaming at him. His head bowed, spotting something on the floor - some of Imp's gorgeous crayon drawings, which he bent down and collected them, tidying them up from a mess into an organised pile. During which his eyes caught a floor panel cracked open, slightly ajar. That's where he must've been hiding during the journey. He hoped it hadn't been too uncomfortable. He reached for the metal plate and tilted it up to see if there was more to tidy. But what he saw moved him far more than he had expected. He gently reached down into the undercarriage, and retrieved out of it, a recorder. One he recognised well. Entrapta's personal recorder. With which she rarely parted. She had clearly gifted it to the boy. Hordak's shaky thumb hovered over the play button, hopeful, eager, and perhaps a little desperate, to hear her voice.

He pressed the play button lightly. And the voice of his beloved came through. He so longed to hear it again, like a lifeline for his soul.

"Hi baby, look, I know things-- things have been tough, it's complicated, you'll understand when you're older. And I know that's something no kid wants to hear, but it's true. Me and that grumpy goof of a father of yours want you to live in peaceful bliss, we want you to have a normal childhood, well, as normal as possible for our family. God knows 'normal' doesn't really run in our family, but for you, we can try. But for that to happen, for others to forgive us, and to leave us alone, your daddy needs to do his work, and sometimes that means he has to disappear and go away for a few days, now and again. I miss him too. You're not the only one who worries. But he'll be okay… he's safe… he's with people he can trust, that'll look after him. He'll be okay… I promise. This isn't like before, the big man's gone, and daddy'll never forget us again, he's better now. This time he'll always come back. It's what he fights for, in more than one way. But until we can be together for good, I thought a present would be nice. In case you get lonely. I know you miss him so I recorded his voice a little bit here and there, unbeknownst to him, but I know he won't mind. Plus, there's plenty of my own findings on here, in case you ever miss your favourite parent. Wink. Wink. Winkety wink. Love you, baby. Just know we're so proud of you. And know you're never alone." And that was when the recording cut out. And Hordak was left that little bit more alone. Paired with the recorder were little drawings of Hordak and Entrapta in their bed back home in Dryl, with little Imp cuddled in the middle. And he could feel his eyes watering.

He owed the boy an apology, obviously. He wiped the tears from his face, smearing his black eye make-up slightly. Imp felt similar guilt, and had enlisted the help of Glimmer to help him find an apology card. There seemed to have been a small settlement based around the station. Nothing major, just a scattering of wooden rundown sheds. One of which looked like a souvenir shop, and luck for them, it was. Imp pulled on Glimmer's arms,

pointed at the store nearby, wiggling his whole little body in its direction, bouncing up and down like a baby would, ‘bababa’.

“OK, OK, I got it. We’ll go.” The Queen remarked, rolling her eyes, though a sweet smile was ever-present on her gorgeous tanned face. She of course obeyed the little boy-bat. She pushed aside the tassels within the doorway of the strange store as she stepped into the hut and was immediately, boisterously greeted by the alien humanoid mushroom-headed vendor.

“Hello, hello, welcome my friend! Come in, come in, make yourselves at home! Always a pleasure to see new faces passing by.” He snapped his fingers and shouted out to the back room of the store. “Honey, customers, we've got customers!” Which prompted, presumably, their wife to enter the shop floor, arms raised, smile as wide as the sea and as bright as the sun.

“Hello, darling! Oh, aren't you gorgeous!?”

“Oh wow, you guys are so nice here, heha. We're just browsing. And not entirely sure what for. The little one's in charge.”

“Oh honey, don't you know that's what children do? You bring them into the world and they turn it upside down. They run it. Ho ho, ha ha.” Imp had leapt out of Glimmer’s grasp onto a card rack counter and began to flick through the abundance of cards, looking for the perfect one! And found it! The boy picked out an apology card with a sad sausage on the front saying ‘Sorry I'm a brat, I'm the wurst!’.

‘Jah!’ He bounced up and down in excitement.

The mushroom lady gushed over the pair. “What an adorable little critter. I've never seen anyone like you, little one. Where did you folks say you were from?”

“Oh. Um. Uh. Planet… Ra…”

“...Huh, never heard of it.”

“Yeah, yeah, it's a pretty small faraway planet. Not even on the maps, you wouldn't know it.” Glim very awkwardly deflected the question with a wide, awkward smile. The small gremlin quickly fluttered up and away out of the store owners range. He landed onto a window sill. Before he could enact any mischief, the boy stopped, frozen and paralysed out of nowhere, and reeled back in what almost looked like disgust, which quickly turned to concern and then fear. The batling flew over to Glimmer and they began to tug on her cape, trying to drag her out of the store, and away. Something had spooked him. “What is it now? Sorry about this, we'll take a rain check. Okay, okay, I'm going.” She followed the strange gremlin out of the store. Glimmer was slightly confused, yet she followed the cherub back to the Annihilation. Bumping, on the way, into V and Lee half-way back.

The vulture man swung his right arm around Glimmer. “Hey cotton candy nerd, good thing we found you. Look, we're on a mission. We need to find a pet store and get Drag a new goldfish 'cause the old one’s kinda dead because we… forgot to feed it.” Lee gave him a glare. “Alright, I forgot to feed it. And we need to swap it out before Drag comes too.”

“Yeah, we're kinda in the middle of something.” Glimmer countered. Imp leapt into V’s hands, frantically pointing behind them at the store they had just come from. The boy seemed outright panicked.

And just then, the store lady made the turn, and entered their line of sight-- “Oh, excuse me, darling, you took the card and you haven't paid.--” --And stopped, frozen in place with fear at the sight of the clones. Eyes wide, skin pale, and a quickened pulse. She stepped back.

Glim turned around to apologise. “Oh sorry, it totally slipped my mind. Here, I–”

“No, no, it's all right. It's on the house.” She quickly changed her tune. The woman backed away, trembling in terror. She, to Glimmer, seemed scared, and harmless, but Lee seemed to have

seen something different. His pupils glowed bright cyan, connoting that he was transmitting a telepathic message to V. Who in turn moved toward the store woman, pulling out a few white and red coins from his pouch, fully willing to pay the woman.

"No, we insist fair's fair, please forgive our oafishness, and accept our payment."

"No, no, honestly, it's perfectly alright. No ill will."

"Then why are you moving towards the gun concealed in the town alarm bell behind you?" Glimmer told V to lay off and to give the retreating store owner some space. The local had no retort. She, in the blink of an eye, turned and ran to the bell and rang it - grabbing the laser rifle from within the bell. Glimmer attempted to reach out to the frightened individual and apologise. But that did not go as planned as Glimmer was greeted by a shotgun pointed directly at her face. "Incoming!" V exclaimed, dragging the Queen out of the way of the incoming fire, covering her while his back took the brunt of the punishment. Until they ducked behind a small ridge.

The entire town seemed to have woken up, all pointing their armaments at the crew. Villagers coming out of every nook and cranny, armed to the teeth. "You stay away from here, you demons!" The store owner shouted, taking his place by his wife.

Another man turned to the store owner with a pitchfork in hand. "I told you they'd come back for revenge!"

"Shut up! We killed the others, we can kill them too." Whoosh. The mob heard something move behind them, sounding like cloth bellowing in the wind. They turned only for their gunbarrels to melt - liquified by the heat rays from the thermo-gauntlets wielded by an infuriated Hordak.

One of the vicious villagers decided to throw a punch at the angered clone, who caught it in his hand and began to apply

pressure to it slowly. “You threaten my son. I should incinerate you where you stand. Every fibre of my being screams for me to do so.” The man looked upon Hordak with dread and fear. He murmured something akin to a plea. Hordak did not care for his words. “But I shall spare you against my better judgement. Leave and do not return or even look in the direction of my family again and you shall be spared.”

The ravenous crowd had seemed to lose their teeth all of a sudden. They remained silent for a moment, heads turning to each other, silently commuting and deciding to abandon their crusade and run away as fast as I could.

Hordak moved forward to ensure everyone was alright, especially Imp, but the batling did not run to him but rather passed him back, into the store and chirped for them to follow him. Imp, however, wasn't leading them into the shop, but rather behind it, to the yard behind the settlements. He looked terrified. Hordak charged his gauntlet, turning his fist into a ball flame and with a single hit felled the back wall of the building, opening a route to the yard. Where the earth looked disturbed, and dug up. There was a pair of shovels impaled in the ground.

But there was still an opening in the earth. Whatever it was, they weren't able to finish burying it completely. And that was when all of them noticed the smell at the same time, the odour of decay. Hordak immediately ordered Moe with a bark to take Imp away from here, back to the ship and to keep him there. He didn't want the boy to see what came next. Moe obeyed the order, and so Imp left reluctantly. After they were gone, Hordak simply stared at the patch of land which without a doubt was a shallow grave. They hesitated. Lee didn't. He was the first to grab hold of a shovel.

“We don't have to do this.” V have protested. Lee did not answer him. He simply continued digging. Hordak soon joined in. They unearthed the earth itself, and soon enough they were greeted with a face not too dissimilar to their own. The expression of fear and sorrow immortalised on their face. A man who never

had a chance to find their own name. Clones. Dead clones. Dozens of them. Horrifically contorted. Stuffed into the ground. And the killing was fresh. They weren't dead long. If only they had arrived a little sooner. “They gone?” Lee didn't respond. He dug his hands into the earth and pulled out a clone body. His red eyes poured over the poor soul, barely hiding the rage behind them. Their pupils darted from side to side. Lee’s clawed hand tore the uniform off the clone’s chest, revealing a blue skin chest with various seams running across it, like hull panelling on a ship. Lee was old. He had been alive for a long time. He had been many things on the war front, one of them being a medic, a thing or two that he had picked up from one of his clone brothers they served with. He input a physical acupuncture code at the side of the rib cage which prompted the chest panel to open up.

“How did you–?”

The opening revealed a reflective metal-like disc with a neon trail around its edge. Typically a bright blue, but now only a sliver remained, while the rest of the circle was a dim red. It was a Memory Disc. The mechanical component and vital internal organ all in one, responsible for recording and storing the memories of an individual - Many clones called it a physical counterpart to a soul. Clones weren’t lucky enough to have those.

Hordak placed a hand on his brother’s shoulder, “Lee, what are you doing?” Hordak questioned, disturbed.

“Their bodies may be gone, beyond salvage, but their minds are not. We can still save them! Excavate their Memory Discs and implant them into new grown healthier bodies. But the window is closing, the Discs cannot survive for long outside of a host vessel. If there were clones stationed here, then that means there must be a Spire here as well from which they were deployed. Each Spire complex contains plenty of ‘supplementary material’ in case of emergencies to grow new bodies. We just need to get the discs there.”

“Except–” Hordak countered.

"Except what?!"

"We're not gonna do that."

"What!? Why would we not?! We have an obligation to save and serve our brothers!"

"Lee, I'm sorry, but these men are already dead. And they have been so for days. What you hold in your hand is a glorified memory stick, an echo of a man. You can't hold a soul in one's hand. They are beating hearts, thinking minds, and unique souls. That's more than just a hard drive. We can't sacrifice a new life to preserve an old one… Lee, The Tenth Law."

"...No Clone Shall Play God." Lee stared into the halo in his hand, a single tear falling down his cheek. "We will not be like him."

There was a commotion behind them within the store, something had fallen over, or rather pushed over. The store owner didn't get far before Lee was on top of him, even as they tried to crawl away, it did not do much good, Lee took hold of the horrified man and flung him out through the front doors.

The mushroom man pleaded but Lee didn't hear him, he didn't even hear Hordak calling him to stop right behind. Lee's fists fell upon the man like hammers atop an anvil, full of boiling rage. He wasn't going to stop until his fists felt the concrete underneath. "You! You did this! You killed my brothers! You-- butcher! I cannot save them, but I can avenge them!" They opened their palm with a hole at its centre and from it shot out a glowing green electro-whip, fast as lightning, cracking a rock next to the man's head in half. He was, without hesitation, about to crack the whip down and split the store owner's head in twain. But as he reeled back, he was stopped, just at the last moment. It was Hordak, who tackled the elderly clone off the local occupant, holding Lee down. Rageful, Lee, not even thinking, elbowed Hordak and shoved the young clone off of his person. While Hordak tried his best to hold them back with all his strength.

"Leave me, boy! He must die! They all must die! Pay for what they've done! Can't you see that!?" Lee wrestled himself out of Hordak's hold. But Hordak didn't let go, he swung himself around using Lee's body weight back in front of the whipping clone. Their hands interlocked, the two titans pushed against each other, digging up trenches in the dirt with their feet firmly planted in the ground. Though Lee was more dexterous and experienced, but Hordak wore Entrapta's new advanced exo-armour, he was stronger. He just held Lee there, on the spot. Lee screamed and yelled and wept, his psychic shriek piercing Hordak's mind, an echo of it even reaching Moe and Imp all the way away at the ship. He screamed and screamed and soon enough he fell to his knees, and into Hordak's arms, sore in his body and mind. And on the ground they both remained with only one thought shared between their minds; The First Law: 'Kill No Man'. The very first law they both had written down for their new commune they forged together on Etheria, the first right written, and the first right their people ever had claim to, a right to live, for all.

"Kill No Man." Lee muttered softly and weakly.

Glimmer could only watch on sorrowfully.

The day had passed on to night or as close as you could get to such a concept on that strange planetoid. Glimmer offered to help however she could. Clones had no burial traditions, no known way to honour the dead, a people who never had a chance to have their own culture. Glimmer suggested something, a tradition from her own home land; to entomb loved ones in a chamber of light, and preserve the cremated ashes under a families home. And to leave a holo-message before the vessel, typically in the form of last words of wisdom to the future generations from the deceased. The Defects weren't familiar with the custom, but they believed it was better than nothing, perhaps this way they would find themselves under the gaze and protection of some god, perhaps even a god that would care for them. That would be nice. The dead deserved that in the least.

Glimmer presided over the ceremony, offering a prayer to The Moons, followed by a conjured flame of light from her palm which she dropped into the resting chamber of the passed clones.

They had removed the Memory Halos from the bodies and had placed them around the burial pit, displaying their picked out final happy moments before the end. After The Fall of Prime, for the first time they were, for a brief time, they were free. No voice in their heads but their own, with room to think their own thoughts - to be themselves. For the first time, and the last. It was in this existential confusion that the clones were pacified enough for the residents to slaughter them. Hordak couldn't blame them, Lee did. They were scared, they were protecting their homes from the occupying force that were the clones - the natives had the right to fight back.

Glimmer and the clones retreated back onboard The Annihilation, mournfully, having lost more than they had gained. The Queen took one more look back at the once beautiful landscape of the planetoid, now tainted in memory, and wordlessly said her goodbyes. Fuel tanks full, they departed. Their continuation of the quest was serenaded by Moe's mournful dirge; The Mournsong Lament. Glimmer had never heard of it, or anything like it. It was equal parts beautiful and haunting. Lee, the weeping man, had no lower jaw, and could speak no words, yet a beautiful resonance somehow emerged from him, a symphony of vibrations; humming, chirping, and purring, which filled the halls of the ship. It sounded sad, she was sure there was a story behind it, but she never asked, it didn't seem like the right time.

The last day was an ordinal, sleep would serve them well. And so Glimmer drifted off to slumber, or at least she tried to. She couldn't help but eavesdrop. "I'm sorry little one. I'm sorry I left, again and again. I'm sorry I've been taken so far away… But my 'I'm sorry's can only take me so far. I will attempt to rectify- I will do my best-... I will stay." The small batling nuzzled into their guardian, already half asleep, "Drift away to slumber, rest well,

and know that you are loved, always, and forever. Your Entrapta and I, value most of all."

Hordak scooped the small infant and softly placed them into a makeshift cradle / crib he had constructed from a small incubation pod which he stuffed with a number of soft cloths to simulate a bed. No luxury. But better than sleeping in the vents. "Trouble sleeping?" He remarked. Glimmer's eyes shot wide open. Shoot. He knew.

"Eh, yeah, just… a lot on my mind." She outed herself.

"I believe your people have a saying; 'A penny for your thoughts', is it? Though I do not know who this Penny is, but I believe I understand the statement; relinquish your bothersome thoughts to a willing ear."

"Are you willing?"

"I suppose I am… Forgiveness from my little spy comes easily. But I believe I still owe an apology, to you. For my words of yesterday, and how I acted… I acted out of raw emotion, during pressured times. Ignoring that you are our only hope of salvation. And for that I am sorry."

"I… humbly accept your apology… and you are forgiven." Glimmer was a little taken aback by this, to say the least. But in a positive way, she supposed. "Will you join me on this couch, for a long overdue conversation?" Hordak nodded as he waltzed from the kitchen corner over the dim livingroom, and softly sat down on the couch next to the Queen who made room for him after her request. She offered some of her blankets, though he quietly refused.

"I've consulted with an advisor of mine, and they've convinced me to rethink my position, and give you a second chance."

"Adora?"

"Yeah, heh, she seems to have faith in you. She fundamentally believes in second chances. Believes in people. And now she's chosen to put her faith in you. Her heart remains her greatest strength. Just when I think I can't fall more in love with her, her heart grows larger."

"...She truly is too kind for this world. And for me."

"She sure is. But she doesn't see it that way. She's reached out her hand to worse, and changed them, for the better; Huntara, Catra… me, if she chose to have it within her to look at me again, I suppose I'd be a hypocrite for giving up on you." The Queen sighed, eyes closed, "Look, I don't know if I can forgive you, you're the reason I've been separated from my father my entire life, you're the reason my mother is dead, you are the reason my world and my people have been thrown into three decades of turmoil and suffering. You treated us like we were lesser than you… But I suppose so did I when it came to you guys. It never occurred to me how… human you all were. You can be hurt. You can be kind. Back at the station, you and Lee had every right to take your vengeance on the residents, but you… maybe we can all use a little selflessness."

"Permission to speak?"

"It's why I asked you here. Permission permissioned."

"I do not blame you for hating me, there is no one in the universe who hates me more than myself. I am cruel, hideous, vile, and that was all I saw within myself or much of my life. Until I met her. She showed me how to love, how to live with myself. And for that I had loved nothing but her. There was a brief time when all I cared for, all I wanted, was to protect Entrapta and my little Imp. That was the case for a while, until I found a new family, and I found myself caring for them, and through them I came to care for all my people, my brothers. And I suppose now I have come to care for all - I never saw life as… precious, before. I was conditioned to believe it was expendable, but now I cannot unsee it."

"What?"

"How matter-of-fact it all is, how simple it all is. There is no grand overseeing power, it is simply just us, here, together - We're all we've got. I suppose I am trying to say that you have every right to hate me, but do not extend this hate upon my brethren. We are small, poor, confused, lost things, ashamed of ourselves, perhaps if we were raised with an upbringing like yours we could have been better off, I envy that, this concept of a 'normal' life."

Glimmer seemed shocked at that confession in particular, envious of her upbringing? She had always , in a way, taken her position for granted, often complained, cooped up in boardrooms and offices, about her mother's stern expectations, she never really appreciated it all until it was all too late. But she was lucky, wasn't she? A full stomach. A warm home. A kindly mother who taught her kindness, love, justice, and compassion for all, fundamentals some never grew up with.

"Though my words may not hold much meaning, I choose to speak them none the less; I am sorry for what I have wrought upon your world, your people, your father, your mother, if I could unmake those decisions, I would. I am sorry."

"..." Glimmer remained engulfed within her own thoughts and remained silent, without answer.

"I understand. I will leave you to rest. Tomorrow is our last day of the journey, I'm sure you'll be glad to be rid of us. Slumber will do you good before your audience with The Council of Worlds."

He lifted himself up and off the couch, about to return to the craft's cockpit to pour over the corrupted baitship footage one more time, when quite suddenly and boisterously a very inebriated V burst out of Drag's quarters into the 'livingroom'. Hordak raised his brow at him, "What happened to you?"

V raised up a clear plastic bag housing a small pocket of water and a small gold fish flippering around, "I got Drag's fish."

Hordak bowed his head and massaged the bridge of his nose, "V."

"Yep?"

"Just go to sleep."

"Yep."

That gave Glim a good chuckle. She heeded Hordak's advice and drifted off to some well earned sleep. Not knowing what was to come.

Day Seven (of Seven)

One more peaceful night of sleep before the big day, before Glimmer would stand before the Council of Worlds of the Known Universe and make her case to them. Convince them that even though they had the cosmos' grandest armada overhead they were no threat, but rather a friend, that they should stand together, Etheria was too small of a world to survive in such a big universe. Etheria was behind on the evolutionary curve, being trapped within Despandos for so long. But hopefully things were about to ch--

The whole Annihilation shook violently enough to awaken Glimmer from her slumber. Turbulence? In space? Groggy, she moved her messy sparkly hair out of the way, scanning the area, sifting through the dark. No clones, but there was something else, a strange, deep electronic noise veering throughout the ship, and a strange blue light which Glim taught travelling throughout and across the ship in the form of a wall of light. They were being scanned, in some way, she assumed. It was too soon for it to be the Conference. They had only entered the Summit System a few hours ago. But if they were in trouble of some kind, one of the clones would have woken her… Speaking of which, where was everyone?

There was Drag, still unconscious, lying on the ground in the corner, cuddled in the embrace of a ginormous pillowfort his

brothers had constructed for him. Nothing new there. Glimmer got up, following up on a hunch, a bad feeling. She felt a strange energy wash over her. She passed the small circular window from which she watched their original launch on her way to the cockpit, and noticed something that alerted her. That something was extremely wrong. The sight made her pick up the pace. She sprinted over to the cockpit. As she got close, she noticed Hordak present at the helm.

She placed a hand on the clone, "Hordak, what's going on?!" I just saw–" Hordak. He wasn't moving, or blinking, or anything. She could tell he was still alive, just immobilised somehow. His Identity Halo was still lit fully, he was in some sort of stasis. At that point she chose to turn her eyes to look out the front windshield.

She wasn't met with the blackness of space as usual, but rather with metal and rivets and artificial light… and movement, a lot of it. They were inside a hangar, somehow pulled within it. And the worst part was the walls of this enigmatic ship bore a familiar sigil; that of the Primusian military. Perhaps they weren't dealing with mere pirate extremist separatists. Much to think over, but one thing was for certain, as the ramp bay doors began to spark and be sawed open, they were being boarded.

Glim thought fast, where could she hide, her mind was still groggy from sleep and the whole interaction with Imp and… that's it! She quickly slid down to the floor paneling and pulled one of tiles off, loosened by Hordak previously, and quietly slipped in, covering herself by returning the tile back to its original position. The second she was concealed, the bay doors fell open with a THUAM!!!

It was a tight fit, but she'd manage, she'd have to if she wanted to survive. She couldn't see the invaders from her vantage point under the floor, all she could hear was the sound of footsteps and then of dragging, where they carting Hordak away?

“Why don’t we just kill these things now? Put a bullet in their heads while they can’t fight back.”

“Did you find the brat-Queen?”

“Eh, no.”

“Do you know where she is?”

“No?”

“Then they stay alive. Shut up, interrogate them, and no more ideas from you. Everyone spread out and find that cotton-candy sprout.”

Rude.

Getting out wasn't the hard part. She simply waited for the pirates to complete their search of the ship and waited for them to leave. She swiftly exited the floor and swiped an empty vial from Hordak’s remote lab in his room and made her way silently to the couch for her bag. They had clearly found it stuffed between the couch cushions and had turned it inside out, but they didn't take the most valuable thing.They overlooked the glass orb of Etherian soil and dirt. She used the vial to scoop up some of the soil - her connection to her home and her magic. The Queen bent the light around her and swiftly vanished to the naked eye. Now, for the hard part; how to find the clones.

She had no idea how to traverse the craft, but she figured her best bet was to follow the troops, and so she did light footed and tiptoeing. She eavesdropped on several conversations on her way, trying to figure out where they kept the brig. She had a few close calls. The floor was squeakier than she expected. She knew they couldn't see her, but it didn't slow her heart rate down in anyway, when they turned around and looked through her. She kept her distance from then on. What now? Think, Glim, think. Lo and behold, an answer presented itself.

Clank. Squeak. Thump. A small plump critter flopped down from the vent overhead and somehow ended up perfectly landing in Glimmer's hands. Bah-bah! Mouthfart. Tongue out. "Imp?! How are you-- Here? Not frozen?" Imp gave the magician a blank stare, then looked down onto his small hands and raised two of his pointing fingers, and them together side-by-side. And then only raised a single finger. Glimmer didn't quite understand. But that wasn't important now, she had the Horde's best spy on her side now.

The boy opened their mouth and an alien voice escaped from within, "How long can the machine hold them in stasis?"

A new voice responded. "Long as it needs to. Don't ask me how it works, but it sure as hell works a treat against the clonies."

"Primus, that thing gives me shivers down my spine. I swear I can hear that thing whispering. What did they call it?"

The second voice paused for a moment before speaking up, "The Psycho Engine."

"Yikes."

"Yeah, I know, right?"

"Really screws with their bad brains."

This gave her an idea. A plan was forming within her mind. Glim sent the eager boy out throughout the air vents back into the belly of the beast. He crawled his way up behind one of the guards he had recorded previously and opened his little yapper; Imp's vocal cords synthesized his pirate friend's voice. "Hey, man, the boss told me to guard the cisco thingie majiggie. Wha-- Where is it again?" Our little ventriloquist.

"Floor 4, next to the brig. Wait, what do you mean? Did you get hit in the head? Are you off your break already?" No response. The battling had scrambled away already.

Imp rendezvoused with Glimmer and set out for the holding cells, trying their best to read the alien letters and numbers along the walls. The duo happened upon what they presumed was some sort of elevator, but there were two guards blocking it. She had to get them away from the doors for just a moment. She curled her hand and began to generate a solar orb within her palm, and placed it against the wall she leaned against, irradiating heat into the corridor, which the guards soon enough felt pretty strongly, as they began to sweat profusely.

And so it wasn't just unbearable inside their armour, it became difficult to breathe within the corridor as itself. And they swiftly left their post to figure out what was happening. Glimmer dashed inside. It took a few tries but she managed to work the elevator, but not fast enough. As the guards returned with an engineer supervisor. Before they piled into the lift, Glimmer had once again turned invisible. The doors slid shut, locking Glim within. Along with the hostiles. It got worse as one of them happened to accidentally brush against her, which gave the pirate quite the scare. Before the pirates could brandish their firearms on the Queen, she summoned a fistful of solar power and hit them with it full force, knocking one of them out. While flash banging the other two from her by opening her palm. Imp leapt at one of the kidnappers and began to scratch their face like an agitated cat. While distracted, Glimmer generated a dual beam of light. Searing the pirates and slamming them into the walls. She concealed their unconscious bodies by wrapping light around them when the doors opened.

The pirate guards patrolling the detention level must have been quite shocked, save to say they had never experienced anything quite like that. Suddenly, out of nowhere, everything went dark. They went blind as Glimmer made their corneas transparent, allowing her to dash past them easily and locking them within that hallway.

The next obstacle was a line of robot wardens, not so easily blinded, their hydraulics hissed to life as they sprinted at the

Queen in offence, summoning electro-batons from their palms and raised it against Glimmer.

But it never made impact as Glim gathered her strength and formed a miniature star in her hand and shot it out as a beam of concentrated light melting through the robotic warden, leaving it a half melted husk. Once the threat was neutralised the Queen began to study the room. There was a machine on the far end of the detention room, merged into the wall. Glimmer didn't have the mind to comprehend the apparatus, but it didn't mean it didn't creep her out any less. The machine, it was surreal and so strange. It almost looked like it had a head and half a torso sticking out of the wall, but instead of flesh and bone, it was comprised of metal. A twirling spinning coil within its cranium and a various network of wires running to and from it. Imp recoiled at its closeness, unnerved.

"What is this?" Glim asked herself.

"A very nifty device, isn't it?" A voice came from behind. Glim whipped around to see a green skinned, antennaed man standing behind her, a cavalry of fellow pirates rallying behind him. "I can't pretend I understand it much. But the dealer we got it from was right. We got good use out of it. Anti-clone weaponry is a pretty hot commodity these days. Costs a pretty penny, though worthy every penny, I'd say. Completely paralyses them, does something to them, tickles their brains in just the right spot, shuts them down, like a telepathic virus. Amazing what modern technology can do for us. I thought you'd appreciate it. I heard you yourself weren't a big fan of the test tube bats."

"Are they safe? Are they here?"

"Huh… not the response I expected."

"You're the one behind all this? You're the one after my head? The crew were just in the way, you want me, let them go. They've got nothing to do with this."

"Oh, but they do. They have to pay for their transgressions against the homeworld just like you. You're a very dangerous woman, Ms Glimmer of BrightMoon, you know that? The power you hold in your hands; Prime's Holy Armada, hovering over your heads on that dust ball of yours - Like a child wielding a gun… Do you think you deserve it? Do you think you're responsible and wise enough to use it?"

"And who is? You? A pirate, and an assassin? You don't seem like the beacon of morality here. An interplanetary empire preying on a young civilisation, ambushing their representative on the way to the Council of the Known Universe calling for aid. Which makes me wonder; how'd you manage that? We for sure thought the baitship would get you off our backs."

"Oh, hehe, a flawless plan, it was not. We managed to board your decoy craft and intercept the security footage before it was transmitted, and managed to alter, corrupt it beforehand. We blew the ship and followed the transmission route as far as we could. How fortunate then that it just so happened that the gas station we lost your trail at was owned by a pair of twin brothers running a money racket. We knew crafts were only fuelled enough to reach each other's stations. Nice extra Romulak, clever. And as such we knew where you would be and we've been on your tail ever since."

"And now you're here to finish the job. So, how handsomely did the Primus government pay you?" That seemed to startle him, "You're not a ragtag group of pirates, no matter how much you want to convince others of that. Not with that loud and proud patriotic military insignia you have plastered over the walls. Stop me when I get something wrong."

"Haha, you're smarter than you look, and you look very stupid. Haha, very handsomely indeed. We're not unruly monsters, killing for killing sake is not what we do. We are countrymen, we kill for nation, for God, for something bigger than ourselves. Surely a royal woman like you can understand that." He pulled out a small rectangular remote-like device, a red switch at its centre, which

he flipped, causing the whole wall on Glimmer’s left to open up, metallic shutters clanking open as they slid up, revealing the clones within the holding cell. Frozen in place like stone statues. Well, almost all of them. Drag was missing, the poor unconscious defect. What had they done to him? “I thought you'd appreciate our little show here; executing these vampiric leechers - breaking bread, so to speak. Oh well, I suppose since you care in one way or another about them. I suppose seeing you tormented works just as well. I'm thinking a focused hypersonic frequency wave from the Psycho Engine that'll split their little bat heads open, should do.”

Glimmer knew all she needed to know. She clenched her fist as if holding a baseball and flung it upward. The ball of condensed light exploded into a flash bang, blinding the attackers. Few things happen next very, very quickly; Imp swiftly scampered over to the head-pirate and bit him on the hand, causing him to drop the remote. And the impling then of course grabbed hold of the device. For Glimmer’s part, she speedily grabbed a handful of soil for a more concentrated blast of light from her fist, which she aimed behind her, which bore a hole in the macabre machine. It took a second, but it imploded. Her second beam of raging light was aimed at the clear glass barrier holding The Defects inside, and of course the paralysed clones fell to the floor, loose, unchained, unrestricted and free to move and speak once more.

To no one's surprise, V was the first to open his mouth. “When I get my hands on you! You're gonna regret being born! Lee, get your foot out of my mouth.”

Hordak, however, was the first on his feet. “Where is Drag? What have you done with him?” He barked, baring his fangs, ready to claw at the head-pirate ready to tear them apart but he was stopped in their tracks.

“I wouldn't be so hasty.” The pirate held up a wriggling Imp attempting to break free from the grasp. “Unless you wish to see your little brat harmed.”

Hordak, almost ground his teeth into powder, his eyes glaring at the man with a stare that could burn people to ashes. “If you harm them, I will mangle you.”

“Bold words for a man standing before a firing squad. Ha, kill them! For Primus! Fire!”And so they did. V hid as many of them behind his metal wings as he could, protecting them from the bullet storm. Glim helped with the rest, expanding a field in front of them, a barrier of heat which melted the bullets in thin air before they could make contact with them, falling like droplets to the floor.

“Imp! Baby; Speak!”

The little battling turned his head around to face the pirate holding them hostage and gave them a little smile. Imp opened his mouth and a devastating sonic BOOM launched from within. Which launched the pirate back across the corridor. Before the baby could flop down on the floor, Hordak caught them in their hands. Imp gave his big brother a big smile and gave a little burp. “Good boy.” He smiled back.

They rushed off, racing through the halls back to the ship. Hope was the key here. Hopefully the ship wasn't impounded or destroyed or jettisoned back into space. Glimmer was taking the lead, with the clones following her as she remembered the route back to the hangar, more or less. She took a few wrong turns, but corrected herself quickly, fighting off any guards in their way. But she noticed that the clones had taken the other path in the fork in the road. She turned back to them, confused. “What are you goobers doing? The hangar is this way!”

“We’re not leaving without Drag, we have to find him first.” Hordak remarked, carrying Moe in his hands. The jailer had done away with their prosthetics, and misplaced Drag elsewhere.

“You should worry about yourself, alien.” The jailer shouted from behind them as they raised their grenade launcher and fired a burning bolt at the team’s feet, exploding on impact, erasing the

floor beneath them, sending them plummeting downwards to the floor below. And finding themselves in the hangar bay.

Bad news, though, was that The Annihilation was on the other end of the ocean of infantry soldiers pointing their weaponry at the crew. Hordes of them. There were too many for them to take out, not without being riddled by bullets from the barrels pointed at them inches away.

There was no way out this time. "Please don't- Don't do this- Please!" Glimmer raised her hands up in protests. But her words fell on deaf ears. The firing squad opened fire. And that was that.The end. The triggers were pulled. The muzzle fire flashed, lighting up Glim's horrified face. Glamour could barely hear herself crying out a 'No!'. Shrieking at the top of her lungs, reaching out, eyes wide and watering. This couldn't be the end. But she knew her field could not shield them from all angles… And yet, she awaited the final judgement…But it did not come. Why? What happened?

The pirates themselves, too, seemed confused. The attacker faced Glimmer, bewildered, they tilted his rifle upward, discombobulated, comically inspecting its barrel, after a second finding that the ammo clip was missing. Glim looked around at all the soldiers. They were all dealing with the same issue. And then suddenly all their guns began to fall apart into separate components. What was happening that neither of the parties could comprehend was the weapons were being disassembled at hyper speed.

With that strategy out of the window, the pirate dropped their arms and withdrew a knife, bearing it down at Glimmer. But before he could complete his first step, he was knocked back and out, hit with such force his chin arching back. And then the soldiers began to fall to the ground like flies, one by one, knocked out by some invisible force. And then standing before them, was Drag, who had arrived with a smile on his face, finally conscious.

“Hey everyone.” He looked around, side to side. “What did I miss?” His voice was much softer and innocent than the rest of his brothers. He reached out his hand to Glimmer, greeting her. “Hi, I'm Dragstar. My brothers call me Drag. Nice to meet you.”

Glimmer returned the smile and shook the young clone’s hand. “Hi, we- uh- we’ve actually technically already met, but eh- it’s nice to meet you properly, Drag. You’ll be glad to know your brothers didn’t lend me your room.”

“And no dead goldfish, hehehe, nope, not anywhere, not anywhen… Who mentioned that?” V chuckled nervously to himself. Dak whapped him on the back of the head.

“Your brothers took good care of you. They're good people.”

That earned an unexpected smile from Hordak.

“Oh, they always do.” Drag’s mouthplate slid apart, parting in two, revealing a pure and bright smile, but one that was missing a few front teeth. Even with that, he still was really cute. In a golden retriever sort of way. Never ashamed to show a wide genuine smile. “Soooo, who’s willing to catch me up to speed?”

Lee slammed his fist against a door panel, locking the door behind them, and in front of an incoming squad of armed troopers, “Later! Get to The Annihilation! We’re getting out of here! Now!” They did as instructed.

They all piled into the dropship like a clown car, there was only one problem, “How are we getting past the closed bay doors?!” Drag questioned.

“They’ll-” Before Hordak could say anymore, he was grabbed from behind, and placed into a chokehold, it was the jailer, which had berated Glim previously.

“You animals aren’t going anywhere!”

They stumbled back toward the open ramp doors of the hovering ship. The army troops had burst into the hangar and we're closing in on the Annihilation, fast. “You're not going anywhere! I will not fail my calling, my country! This will be a righteous killing! For Primus!”

“V, hit the gas.” Hordak roared, struggling against his attacker’s hold.

“But you said to never touch- ah who am I kidding? Let's go!” He screamed at the top of his lungs as he lunged at the throttle lever, pushing it to the max capacity, which caused the whole spaceship to snap forward as if reality itself had lost frames in between. Caused Hordak and the pirate grappling with him to tumble backwards out of the ship doors, only for Glimmer to catch Hordak’s hand just at the last moment, saving him, while the attacker fell back down onto the hangar floor beneath. The Queen and the Lord exchanged a nod. Bay doors closed. The ship rammed through the barricade and they were out, and off, on the run.

“Woohoo!” V celebrated, cackling like a maniac. “Told you I was a good pilot!”

“Don't celebrate yet old man, we're still getting fired at!” Moe held tightly onto the back cockpit seat to stop himself from being thrown around on the floor, the poor clone was still missing his legs. True enough, the massive pirate craft had opened fire on them. V now had his work cut out for him, having to bob and weave amongst the barrage of laser fire.

“Relax, kiddo. You've got the best pilot in the universe chaperoning you-- oh what's this button do? Something ‘KATOONK’ed somewhere off the ship. “I’m sure that’s fine.”

Hordak stepped up to the cockpit, “Why did we just eject the wine cellar?”

Drag worked his brow, “We have a wine cellar?”

“Not anymore, HA!” V barked out a laugh, swerving off to the side causing the whole crew to tumble to the floor. “Gonna miss that hiding spot.” He spun the steering wheel, forcing the drop ship to twirl like a corkscrew.

“Moe, you're the closest to navigation! Tell me we're gonna get to the conference station before V kills us!” Hordak spoke out from under Drag and Moe.

“Well, believe it or not, we've actually gotten lucky for once. We just entered the solar system the conference inhabits. Few more star-klicks and we’re in hailing range.” Moe responded.

“Your Majesty, we'll need you up front. They'll need to hear your voice when we get in range. Their backup might be our only way out of this.” Hordak proclaimed.

BOOM! A direct hit. The entire Annihilation shook, the hit had shredded much of its hull frame, leaving flame and smoke spawning within its walls. Their space coffin began to crumble.

“We’re losing the engine, it's flickering.” Moe screamed.

“Which one?” V asked.

“The only one we have.”

“Ah.”

Glimmer held up the veil of Etherian soil close to her chest and stationed herself at the back of the ship, reaching out her hands. “You keep us moving, I'll keep us living.” She closed her eyes and drew in a deep breath. And extended her reach beyond the physical. Her influence stretched out past the walls of the ship, through the void of space, and out there she could sense the hot, burning laser bolts heading towards them. The bolts of light. And she, was the Queen of Light.

“What’s she doin’?”

“I don't know, keep your eyes on the ‘road’ and keep flying.” Hordak barked the order at the would-be-pilot.

V took that as a challenge and aimed them straight at a field of asteroids that fenced the Conference mega-structure off from the rest of the Summit System, and began to bob and weave between the giant boulders.

“Are you crazy!?”

“Oh brother, we both know the answer to that.”

He hit the gas and rocketed toward there awaiting doom, headed to a clearing between two hulking asteroids on a collision course with each other. The opening between the two was closing too quickly for comfort. His brothers thought of arguing but fell silent under the pressure of the moment. Their only hope was that the pressure of the void of space would not crush them. The Annihilation’s wings flapped as if belonging to an organic bat, carrying them all at a speed too difficult to observe by naked eyes, as if carried by the solar winds, V daring it to tear them asunder.

They made their approach, squeezing through, but no matter how skilled V’s flying was, the manoeuvrability was limited. For the pirates, it was like shooting fish in a barrel, and so a laser bolt the size of their entire ship was lobbed at their escaping vessel. And this was where Glimmer stepped up, sensing the speeding, scorching projectile, reaching out to it and bending it to her will; dispersing its energy into every direction around the ship before it had the chance to make contact. Light was her domain. Those who opposed her would do well to remember that. V pushed the engine so far it almost gave out, giving off a shrieking screech as The Annihilation just narrowly escaped the crushing force of the colliding celestial bodies.

The pirate captain however, must have not felt that confident about their piloting skills as they swerved and killed their engines,

knowing the ship of their size would never fit through, resulting in them slamming into the immense wall of space rock.

"Woohoo!" The vulture man howled in celebration. They made it. They actually made it. Hordak even gave V a celebratory pat on the shoulder and a warm smile. Hordak turned around and made his way to the Queen, who had sat herself down on the cold floor at the back of their ship, exhausted. He sat down beside her after a moment.

"You saved my brothers. You saved my son… After everything I have done… I'm sorry… Thank you…"

"Thank you, Hordak… Look, I don't know if I can ever forgive you for what you've taken from me. But I realise that you're trying to be better and I won't lower my moral character just because I'm hurt. I never bothered to see you all as people - and what does it say about a Queen who doesn't serve her people? And for that, I, too am sorry."

"I… accept your apology." Hordak remarked slightly confused at the apology that wasn't really necessary in his opinion.

They made it. The Conference spacestation. The landing was rough, but they managed to walk it off. Suffice it to say V was very proud. "I told you I was a good pilot. BAM! HA!"

"Ugh." Moe waved his boasting brother off as he ventured over to his art corner ensuring all of his pieces were intact. He smiled softly as he pulled out a recent painting they had made at the beginning of their journey. He managed to find one of his spare wheelchairs that hadn't been taken by the raiders, thankfully, and he wheeled himself over to the excited and wide-eyed Drag. "Anyway, Drag. What'd'ya think? Come on, where's my wholesome reaction I paid for?"

-Gasp!- "It's gorgeous, Moe, thanks. Is that Verrus Centralus?! Aww man, I missed it? No way. I hear their lunar slugs shine so bright it looks like Centralus is glistening, even from orbit! Did you

use glitter on the canvas to convey it? It's awesome. How long did it take you? Not too long, I hope."

"Any amount of time spent on these for you is worth it, bud."

"You think that's the end, oh no buster, check your brochure rack, ya got some new reading material in there." V patted Drag on the shoulder as Lee wordlessly handed him one of the pamphlets, showing his softer side quietly, which spawned stars and sparkles in the young speedster's eyes.

"We can even visit them sometime later, if you wish." Lee telepathically proposed.

"Where were you anyway? You know, back on the Primusian ship?" V asked.

"Oh, let me tell you, they threw me into a trash compactor-" However, their brother's conversation was interrupted by a number of gunbarrels pointed at them by the Conference security guards. They were clones afterall, the scourge and blight of the universe. But Glimmer quickly sprung from out behind the clones, positioning herself between them and the readied weaponry.

"It's alright, soldier, they're with me!"

"Lady Glimmer?! Are you alright?!"

"I am, and all thanks to my security detail here, the finest crew I could ever ask for." The comment drew a small smile from Hordak. "Now, these fine gentlemen have saved my life and I expect that your men will show them the utmost respect and allow them to your finest accommodations and amenities for the next few days of our stay."

"Uhm, y- yes of course, your majesty." The guards answered shakingly looking back and forth between each other.

"Wonderful. And furthermore I have much to discuss with the Cidadels's Security Head and to file an assassination attempt

report, carried out on my head, by the Primusian military no less - hilariously enough I do believe their heads of state are present for the Conference today. Of which, I have evidence thanks to this little hero." Glim gestured to little Imp who hopped onto her shoulder. He opened his little mouth, which prompted a recording of the jailer head pirate and their lunatic monologue from before. "We were attacked, my people were kidnapped, and I'll have the people responsible for this brought to justice. The pirates' vessel potentially lays disabled and damaged just along the system's asteroid belt, if you hurry you can still catch them." She ordered them around as she marched onward past the guards, who tried to keep up with her.

"Um, yes, ma'am."

But she stopped only a few paces away as something came to her mind, she realised she hadn't finished her conversation with Hordak - there was still something she had to say. She turned around, reached out her hand to Hordak and called him forth, "Hordak, please approach." Surprised by the formal yet gentle address he obeyed his Queen's command. "Lord Hordak of Dryl, by decree of the crown, I grant you full and total approval for your crew to act as the ughhh– newly formed 'Search and Rescue Committee', operating with the full support and backing of the Etherian Princess Alliance - To scour the known universe for your scattered brethren and bring them to the safety of our home; I would be honoured if your people would call Etheria home, and save haven. If you would have it."

Hordak was once again taken aback, but in the most pleasant way. He looked cheerfully back at Lee, who just proudly nodded at his mentee. Hordak happily took Glimmer's hand and shook it, sealing the agreement, "Thank you, your excellency. For handing us a voice. You will not regret this. And, good luck with your speech."

Glim ventured off to make her report, taking Imp briefly to record a copy of the evidence, the boy would rejoin the crew soon enough and the boys experienced such luxury and comfort the

likes of which they had never experienced; finest foods, drinks, sleeping quarters, a great baby daycare, a spa and sauna which turned out to be Moe's new obsession he never knew he needed. But nothing beat the sweet home of the Annihilation, and they would oft return to the comforts of the familiar, taking a family dinner together within each others' company onboard the dropship. Even having Glimmer join them for a night or two.

The Defects, in turn, tuned in to watch Glimmer's speech before the Council, and she did great, receiving a standing ovation, winning over the crowd, and new allies. Hordak did not know what became of the Primusians, he did not have much faith in anything productive being done among the wealthy inner circles. He assumed the officials were given a slap on the wrist and allowed to continue their deals and transactions, but now his team knew to keep a close eye on them. Hopefully Etheria's new allies would ward any future assassination attempts off.

The week passed by swiftly, and the next week was greeted with Adora's arrival at the Conference station, just like she promised. The first thing she did after stepping off the transport was tackle her girlfriend and embraced her, lifting Glimmer off the ground effortlessly, planting numerous kisses on her face, and Glim was not complaining. All was right in the world.

"So?... My plan worked?" Adora gave her a small cute smile looking down at her love, dreamfully.

"Oh, I guess so, quiet you." Glimmer raised up on her tiptoes and planted a warm kiss on her partner's lips, "Why do you have to be so damn tall? I missed you so much." She placed her head against Adora's shoulder, "How's home? How's everyone doing?"

"We miss you. But Entrapta managed to catch a broadcast of your speech, we all watched it, and we were cheering you on the whole way through. They wish they could be here, but they're holding down the fort back home until you get back. But you know, nothing new much, saved the world again - pretty standard. Oh, Peri got a new cat, she's so cute!"

"Well, that's good, hehe." Glim chuckled, relieved. "I'm just sorry you had to come all this way just for you to pick me up and turn right back."

"Don't you dare worry about it." Adora reassured her girlfriend, as she caught the sight of a lone Hordak from the corner of her eye, sitting on the ground, leaning against a far wall. The little Imp on his shoulder, munching on some delicious savoury hot pocket. "Hey, baby, you mind if I take a small detour while you pack up?" Adora planted a kiss on Glim's forehead.

"Oh, yeah, sure. You do you."

The Princess of Power approached the clone, "Mind if I join you?"

"Not at all." The defect remarked as he fiddled with a data-pad with some kind of high-tech screwdriver. The radiant valkyrie warrior sat herself down next to the boys.

"I just wanted to say; Thank you for keeping Glimmer safe."

"Hmm, I propose it is the opposite way around. My brothers owe their lives to her."

"She's as tough as nails."

"And she is welcome to set foot aboard The Annihilation any time, a true defect at heart." He remarked truthfully and boastfully. Though something did crept into his mind, a thought, and now that The She-Ra had approached him he had a chance to ask her the question. "This whole journey, this mission… It has been quite an interesting experience… Why did you choose me for this assignment? Why did you have faith in me to carry out such an important task? Safeguarding your one true love?"

She moved slightly, tilting her head up to the sky. She considered the question and her words carefully. "Suppose, in a way I owe you." Hordak quirked his eyebrow, confused. "I owe you my life. You saved me when Light Hope sent me through the

portal when I was a baby. You could have just left me out there - a clone so alien to anything that I was - years before Entrapta, before any positive influence or outer stimuli - an unprompted act of good. It wasn't logical, you gained nothing from it. I've thought back on it a lot these past few years. Why did you save me that day?”

“...I don't know.” He replied truthfully.

“This random, inexplicable act of simple goodness, all dominoed into saving the universe. Without you, I would have never met my friends, my love. I would have never saved the world, never would have tasted food or smelled flowers. It made me think, without Glimmer giving me a chance and trusting me with the Sword. I would have never become She-Ra, without giving Catra another chance she wouldn't have saved me from the Heart… Point being; I choose to believe in people because you never know when people can surprise you. I choose to put my faith in people.”

“Hmm, that is a nice sentiment. I struggle to put that much faith in anything these days.”

“Well, maybe you can put some faith in this--” She gave Imp a little chin scratch, drawing a cute chirp from the boy. She stood up, ready to depart. “--A fundamentalist hordesman who, through love, became a force for good. Now where have I heard that before? And what kind of a hypocrite would that make me if I gave up on you?”

She left him with that nugget of wisdom as she departed back to the ship and to Glimmer’s side as she exited the complex, fully packed and ready to go home. The Queen looked back at him and gave him a slight nod, which he returned.

But he didn't watch the two lovebirds waltz to the royal transport as a ‘beep’ from the data-pad in hand caught his attention. As it could have meant only one thing; a notification of an incoming transmission. Which Hordak, of course, answered.

His eyes widened and grew watery as the image of the other side came through and depixelated. And on the other side was his beloved.

"Baby!" Entrapta joyously exclaimed, flailing out her hands as if trying to hug her boys. Imp, in return, reached out for his mom 'Cha!' he happily babbled. "Oh my stars, I finally managed to get through. The communications array was acting up the whole time. You wouldn't believe what I had to go through to fix it. I had to disassemble and kill a God A.I. by decrypting a nebula server farm." She continued to happily yap to her partner, who just quietly listened eagerly to his love's angelic voice, hanging onto every word, while Imp showed off his treat that he was eating to her. "-And then!... Oh sorry, carried away… I missed you."

"No, no, please go on. I missed you too."

End of Act Three (of Three)

The End

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